

Recipe: Pirozhki (Baked Yeast Hand Pies)

Ingredients: Dough: yeast, warm milk, sugar, flour, butter, egg, salt.

Filling: mashed potatoes, sautéed onions (or cooked ground meat)

Instructions: Dissolve yeast and sugar in warm milk; let sit until frothy. Mix with flour, melted butter, egg, and salt to form a soft yeast dough. Knead well and let rise in a warm place for 1 hour until doubled. Punch down the dough and divide it into small balls. Roll each ball into a flat circle. Place a spoonful of your chosen filling (like seasoned mashed potatoes mixed with plenty of sautéed onions) in the center. Pinch the edges securely together over the filling to form an oval pocket. Place seam-side down on a baking sheet, brush with beaten egg wash, and bake at 190°C for 20-25 minutes until deep golden brown.

Substitutions: Popular fillings include braised cabbage, hard-boiled egg with green onions, or sweet apple jam.

Recipe: Syrniki (Sweet Cheese Fritters)

Ingredients: farmers cheese (tvorog/quark), egg, sugar, flour, vanilla extract, pinch of salt, butter or oil (for frying)

Instructions: Mash the farmers cheese with a fork or press it through a sieve to remove lumps. Stir in the egg, sugar, vanilla extract, and a pinch of salt until smooth. Add 2-3 tablespoons of flour—just enough to hold the mixture together without making it heavy. Scoop out portions of the dough, roll them lightly in extra flour, and flatten them gently into thick, round patties. Heat butter or oil in a skillet over medium-low heat. Fry the patties for 4-5 minutes per side until they form a golden-brown crust and are cooked completely through the center. Serve warm with honey, jam, or sour cream.

Substitutions: Ricotta cheese can be used if authentic Eastern European farmers cheese is unavailable, but drain it well first.

Recipe: Medovik (Russian Honey Layer Cake)

Ingredients: honey, sugar, butter, eggs, baking soda, flour. Frosting: sour cream (smetana), heavy cream, powdered sugar

Instructions: Melt honey, sugar, and butter together in a saucepan over low heat. Stir in baking soda, causing the mixture to foam and turn a deep caramel color. Remove from heat and whisk in eggs one by one, then mix in flour to form a soft dough. Divide the dough into 8 equal pieces. Roll each piece out very thin directly onto baking paper, prick with a fork, and bake at 180°C for 4-5 minutes per layer. Trim the edges while warm to form perfect circles, saving the scraps. Whip sour cream, heavy cream, and powdered sugar together to make the frosting. Stack the layers, spreading a generous amount of frosting between each. Coat the top and sides with frosting, then grind the saved cake scraps into fine crumbs and dust the entire cake. Let rest in the fridge for 12-24 hours to soften.

Substitutions: Greek yogurt can be blended with sour cream if you prefer a sharper, tangy contrast to the sweet honey.

Recipe: Classic Beef Stroganoff

Ingredients: beef sirloin or tenderloin, cremini mushrooms, onions, sour cream (smetana), beef broth, flour, butter, Dijon mustard, salt, pepper

Instructions: Cut the beef across the grain into thin strips. Melt butter in a large skillet over high heat and sear the beef rapidly for 1-2 minutes per side until browned but not fully cooked; transfer to a plate. In the same skillet, lower the heat, add more butter, and sauté sliced onions and mushrooms until soft. Sprinkle flour over the vegetables and stir. Pour in beef broth and Dijon mustard, bringing it to a simmer. Whisk in the sour cream, then return the beef and its juices to the pan. Simmer gently for 2-3 minutes until the sauce thickens. Serve hot over egg noodles or mashed potatoes.

Substitutions: Chicken breast or pork tenderloin can be used instead of beef.

Recipe: Siberian Pelmeni (Meat Dumplings)

Ingredients: Dough: flour, water, egg, salt. Filling: ground beef, ground pork, onions, garlic, ice water, salt, pepper

Instructions: Mix flour, egg, water, and salt to form a firm dough; knead for 10 minutes, wrap, and let rest. For the filling, combine ground beef, ground pork, finely minced onions, garlic, salt, and pepper. Mix in a few tablespoons of ice water to ensure the filling stays juicy. Roll the dough out very thin. Cut out small circles using a glass. Place a small spoonful of filling in the center of each circle, fold the dough in half to seal the edges into a half-moon, and pull the two corners together, pinching them to form a classic round dumpling shape. Boil in salted water or beef broth for 5 minutes after they float to the top.

Substitutions: Use ground turkey or chicken for a lighter dumpling filling.

Recipe: Golubtsi (Stuffed Cabbage Rolls)

Ingredients: whole cabbage head, ground beef, ground pork, cooked white rice, onions, carrots, tomato paste, sour cream, broth, salt, pepper

Instructions: Boil a whole head of cabbage in a large pot for 10 minutes until the outer leaves soften; carefully peel away the individual large leaves and cut away the thick central ribs. Mix ground beef, ground pork, cooked rice, finely chopped onions, salt, and pepper together. Place a generous spoonful of the meat mixture near the stem end of a cabbage leaf, tuck in the sides, and roll it up tightly. Sauté grated carrots and onions in a pan, stir in tomato paste, sour cream, and broth to make a sauce. Arrange the cabbage rolls tightly in a baking dish, pour the sauce over them, cover, and bake at 180°C for 1 hour.

Substitutions: Tomato sauce mixed with a bit of sugar can stand in for the tomato paste and sour cream mixture.

Recipe: Chicken Kiev

Ingredients: chicken breasts, unsalted butter, garlic, fresh dill, parsley, flour, eggs, breadcrumbs, oil (for frying), salt, pepper

Instructions: Mix softened butter with minced garlic, chopped dill, parsley, and a pinch of salt. Shape the herb butter into small logs and freeze until completely solid. Pound chicken breasts between sheets of plastic wrap until thin and even. Place a frozen butter log in the center of each chicken breast, roll the chicken tightly around the butter, tucking the edges in secure so no butter can escape during cooking. Dredge each rolled chicken breast in flour, dip completely in beaten eggs, and coat thoroughly in breadcrumbs (repeat egg and breadcrumbs for a double coating). Fry in hot oil until golden brown, then transfer to a 180°C oven for 10-12 minutes to finish cooking.

Substitutions: Use panko breadcrumbs for an extra crunchy outer crust.

Recipe: Traditional Red Borscht

Ingredients: beets, beef shank, cabbage, potatoes, carrots, onions, tomato paste, vinegar, garlic, dill, sour cream (smetana)

Instructions: Simmer beef shank in water for 1.5 hours to create a rich broth. Remove beef, shred it, and return to the pot. Add cubed potatoes and shredded cabbage to the simmering broth. Meanwhile, sauté grated beets, carrots, and onions in a pan with tomato paste and a splash of vinegar (to preserve the vibrant red color) for 15 minutes. Transfer the sautéed vegetables into the main pot and simmer until all vegetables are tender. Stir in minced garlic and fresh dill, then turn off the heat. Serve hot with a dollop of sour cream.

Substitutions: Omit the beef and use vegetable broth for a vegetarian version; lemon juice can replace vinegar.

Recipe: Shchi (Classic Cabbage Soup)

Ingredients: fresh cabbage, pork or beef ribs, potatoes, carrots, onions, peppercorns, bay leaves, fresh dill, sour cream

Instructions: Boil pork or beef ribs in a large pot with bay leaves and peppercorns for about an hour, skimming off any foam. Add shredded fresh cabbage and cubed potatoes to the broth. In a separate pan, sauté chopped onions and grated carrots until soft and golden, then stir them into the soup. Simmer on low heat for another 20 minutes until the cabbage is perfectly tender. Garnish generously with chopped dill and serve with dark rye bread and sour cream.

Substitutions: Use sauerkraut instead of fresh cabbage to make "Kislye Shchi" (Sour Shchi).

Recipe: Olivier Salad (Russian Potato Salad)

Ingredients: boiled potatoes, boiled carrots, hard-boiled eggs, bologna (or cooked chicken), dill pickles, canned peas, mayonnaise, salt, pepper

Instructions: Dice the boiled potatoes, carrots, hard-boiled eggs, bologna, and dill pickles into small, uniform cubes (about the size of the peas). Place all the diced ingredients into a large mixing bowl and add the drained canned peas. Toss everything together gently. Fold in mayonnaise until the salad is evenly coated, then season with salt and black pepper to taste. Chill in the refrigerator for at least one hour before serving.

Substitutions: Use boiled beef or turkey instead of bologna for a more traditional flavor profile.

Recipe: Blini (Russian Crepes)

Ingredients: flour, milk, eggs, sugar, salt, melted butter, baking powder, vegetable oil (for frying)

Instructions: Whisk together eggs, sugar, and salt in a bowl. Pour in half of the milk, then gradually sift in the flour and baking powder, whisking continuously to prevent lumps from forming. Whisk in the remaining milk and melted butter until you have a smooth, thin batter. Heat a lightly oiled skillet over medium-high heat. Pour a small ladle of batter into the center and swirl the pan instantly to coat the bottom. Cook for 1-2 minutes until the edges turn golden, flip, and cook for another 30 seconds. Stack them on a plate, brushing each with melted butter.

Substitutions: Use kefir or buttermilk instead of regular milk for thicker, slightly tangy blini.

Recipe: Green Mango Salad (Tam Mamuang)

Ingredients: sour green mango, garlic, bird's eye chilies, roasted peanuts, dried shrimp, fish sauce, lime juice, palm sugar

Instructions: Peel and shred the sour green mango into thin strips. In a mortar and pestle, pound garlic and bird's eye chilies coarsely. Add palm sugar, fish sauce, and lime juice, mixing well to dissolve the sugar. Toss in the shredded mango, dried shrimp, and roasted peanuts, bruising the ingredients gently with the pestle so they absorb the dressing.

Substitutions: Green papaya can be treated exactly the same way to make Som Tum; skip dried shrimp for a vegan layout.

Recipe: Minced Chicken Salad (Larb Gai)

Ingredients: minced chicken, shallots, mint leaves, cilantro, green onions, toasted rice powder, lime juice, fish sauce, chili flakes

Instructions: Cook minced chicken in a dry skillet with two tablespoons of water over medium heat, stirring continuously to break it up until fully cooked; remove from heat. Stir in sliced shallots, chopped green onions, cilantro, and fresh mint leaves. Add fish sauce, fresh lime juice, dried chili flakes, and toasted rice powder (khao khua), tossing thoroughly.

Substitutions: Minced pork or turkey works beautifully; toasted rice powder is essential for the authentic crunchy texture.

Recipe: Mango Sticky Rice (Khao Niew Mamuang)

Ingredients: glutinous rice, ripe sweet mangoes, coconut milk, sugar, salt, toasted sesame seeds

Instructions: Soak glutinous rice in water for 4 hours, then steam for 20 minutes until tender. In a saucepan, warm coconut milk, sugar, and a pinch of salt together until dissolved. Pour three-quarters of this warm coconut syrup over the hot cooked sticky rice, stirring gently, and let it rest covered for 20 minutes to absorb. Serve the rice with sliced sweet mangoes and drizzle with the remaining syrup and sesame seeds.

Substitutions: Use coconut cream for an even richer finish; replace white sugar with palm sugar for a golden color syrup.

Recipe: Thai Fish Cakes (Tod Mun Pla)

Ingredients: white fish paste, red curry paste, kaffir lime leaves, French beans, egg, fish sauce, sugar, oil

Instructions: In a food processor, blend firm white fish fillets into a smooth paste. Mix in red curry paste, an egg, a splash of fish sauce, and a pinch of sugar until a sticky dough forms. Stir in finely sliced French beans and thinly julienned kaffir lime leaves. Shape into flat, round patties and deep-fry in medium-hot oil for 3 minutes per side until puffed and golden brown.

Substitutions: Use minced shrimp instead of fish; serve with a sweet chili sauce mixed with diced cucumbers.

Recipe: Sweet Basil Chicken Stir-Fry (Pad Kra Prow)

Ingredients: minced chicken, holy basil leaves, garlic, bird's eye chilies, oyster sauce, soy sauce, sugar, oil, egg

Instructions: Coarsely crush garlic and bird's eye chilies. Heat oil in a wok and fry the chili-garlic mix until pungent. Add minced chicken, stir-frying on high heat until cooked through. Pour in oyster sauce, soy sauce, and a pinch of sugar. Toss rapidly for 1 minute, turn off heat, and stir in a large handful of fresh holy basil leaves until wilted. Serve with a crispy fried egg over rice.

Substitutions: Use regular sweet basil if holy basil is unavailable; minced pork or beef can replace chicken.

Recipe: Classic Tom Yum Goong

Ingredients: shrimp, lemongrass, galangal, kaffir lime leaves, bird's eye chilies, oyster mushrooms, fish sauce, lime juice, chili paste, water

Instructions: Bring water to a boil in a pot. Add bruised lemongrass stalks, sliced galangal, torn kaffir lime leaves, and crushed bird's eye chilies, simmering for 5 minutes until highly fragrant. Toss in oyster mushrooms and clean shrimp, cooking for 3 minutes until shrimp turn pink. Turn off heat, stir in fish sauce, fresh lime juice, and Thai chili paste (nam prik pao).

Substitutions: Add chicken instead of shrimp to turn it into Tom Yum Gai; use evaporated milk for a creamy version.

Recipe: Creamy Tom Kha Gai

Ingredients: chicken, coconut milk, chicken broth, lemongrass, galangal, kaffir lime leaves, mushrooms, fish sauce, lime juice, chilies

Instructions: Combine chicken broth and coconut milk in a pot and bring to a gentle simmer. Add sliced galangal, bruised lemongrass, and kaffir lime leaves. Drop in bite-sized chicken pieces and sliced mushrooms, simmering for 8 to 10 minutes until the chicken is tender. Remove from heat, stir in fish sauce, fresh lime juice, and crushed bird's eye chilies.

Substitutions: Use vegetable broth and tofu for a vegetarian layout; adjust chilies to control heat levels.

Recipe: Thai Green Curry (Gaeng Keow Wan)

Ingredients: chicken, green curry paste, coconut milk, bamboo shoots, Thai eggplants, kaffir lime leaves, basil, fish sauce, palm sugar, oil

Instructions: Heat a tablespoon of oil or coconut cream in a deep pot, add green curry paste, and fry for 2 minutes until fragrant. Gradually pour in coconut milk while stirring. Add chicken slices, Thai eggplants, and bamboo shoots, bringing to a simmer for 10 minutes. Season with fish sauce and palm sugar, then stir in fresh sweet basil and kaffir lime leaves.

Substitutions: Firm tofu and mixed vegetables work perfectly; use regular eggplants if Thai eggplants are missing.

Recipe: Rich Massaman Curry

Ingredients: beef or chicken, Massaman curry paste, coconut milk, potatoes, onions, roasted peanuts, cinnamon, fish sauce, tamarind paste

Instructions: Fry Massaman curry paste in coconut cream until fragrant. Add cubed beef or chicken, tossing to coat with the paste. Pour in the remaining coconut milk and a splash of water, adding potato chunks, sliced onions, a cinnamon stick, and roasted peanuts. Simmer on low heat for 25 minutes (longer for beef) until tender. Stir in fish sauce and tamarind paste.

Substitutions: Duck makes a rich alternative; replace palm sugar with brown sugar if needed.

Recipe: Authentic Red Curry (Gaeng Ped)

Ingredients: pork or chicken, red curry paste, coconut milk, bamboo shoots, bell peppers, kaffir lime leaves, basil, fish sauce, oil, sugar

Instructions: Fry red curry paste in a pot with a little oil until fragrant and oil separates. Whisk in coconut milk and bring to a simmer. Slide in pork slices, bamboo shoots, and sliced bell peppers, cooking for 8 minutes until tender. Season the curry base with fish sauce and sugar, finishing with torn kaffir lime leaves and fresh sweet basil.

Substitutions: Shrimp cooks much faster, so add it in the final 3 minutes; frozen bamboo shoots work fine.

Recipe: Classic Pad Thai

Ingredients: rice noodles, shrimp or tofu, eggs, bean sprouts, garlic chives, peanuts, tamarind paste, fish sauce, palm sugar, oil, lime

Instructions: Soak flat rice noodles in warm water until pliable. Mix tamarind paste, fish sauce, and palm sugar in a bowl to make the sauce. Heat oil in a wok, sauté shrimp or tofu, push to the side, crack in eggs, and scramble. Toss in the drained noodles and tamarind sauce, stir-frying rapidly on high heat. Add bean sprouts and garlic chives, tossing for 1 minute. Serve hot topped with crushed roasted peanuts and fresh lime wedges.

Substitutions: Use soy sauce instead of fish sauce for a vegetarian profile; swap garlic chives with green onions.

Recipe: Thai Fried Rice (Khao Pad)

Ingredients: pre-cooked jasmine rice, chicken, eggs, onions, garlic, Chinese broccoli, fish sauce, soy sauce, sugar, oil, cilantro

Instructions: Heat oil in a wide wok, fry minced garlic and sliced chicken until cooked through. Push to the side, crack in eggs, and scramble gently. Toss in cold, leftover jasmine rice and chopped Chinese broccoli. Drizzle with fish sauce, soy sauce, and a pinch of sugar, stir-frying on maximum heat for 3 minutes until the rice grains are lightly toasted. Garnish with chopped cilantro and serve with cucumber slices.

Substitutions: Shrimp or pork can replace chicken; regular broccoli works if Chinese broccoli is unavailable.

Recipe: Pineapple Fried Rice (Khao Pad Sapparod)

Ingredients: pre-cooked rice, shrimp, pineapple chunks, cashews, raisins, onions, garlic, curry powder, fish sauce, soy sauce, oil

Instructions: Heat oil in a wok, stir-fry minced garlic, sliced onions, and shrimp until the shrimp turns pink. Add pineapple chunks, raisins, and a teaspoon of yellow curry powder, stirring for 1 minute. Toss in cold pre-cooked jasmine rice, cashews, fish sauce, and soy sauce. Stir-fry vigorously on high heat for 3 minutes until fragrant and evenly yellow.

Substitutions: Serve inside a hollowed-out pineapple shell for presentation; omit raisins if you dislike sweet notes.

Recipe: Spicy Drunken Noodles (Pad Kee Mao)

Ingredients: wide flat rice noodles, chicken, holy basil leaves, bell peppers, onions, garlic, bird's eye chilies, oyster sauce, soy sauce, oil

Instructions: Pound garlic and bird's eye chilies together into a coarse paste. Heat oil in a wok and fry this chili-garlic paste until highly aromatic. Add chicken slices, onions, and bell peppers, stir-frying until chicken is cooked. Toss in wide flat rice noodles, oyster sauce, and soy sauce. Stir-fry over high heat for 2 minutes, turn off heat, and toss in fresh holy basil leaves until wilted.

Substitutions: Italian basil can stand in for holy basil, though the flavor profile changes slightly; use tofu for meat-free.

Recipe: Pad See Ew (Soy Sauce Noodles)

Ingredients: wide flat rice noodles, pork, Chinese broccoli, eggs, garlic, sweet dark soy sauce, oyster sauce, soy sauce, oil, vinegar

Instructions: Heat oil in a wok and fry minced garlic until fragrant. Add pork slices and cook through. Push everything to the side, crack in eggs, and scramble. Toss in wide flat rice noodles, chopped Chinese broccoli, sweet dark soy sauce, oyster sauce, and regular soy sauce. Stir-fry on very high heat without moving too much at first to let the noodles get a smoky, charred edge.

Substitutions: Sliced chicken breast cooks just as well; regular soy sauce mixed with brown sugar can replace dark soy sauce.

Recipe: Classic Palak Paneer

Ingredients: spinach, paneer, onions, tomatoes, ginger-garlic paste, green chilies, garam masala, cream, oil, salt

Instructions: Blanch spinach leaves in boiling water for 2 minutes, then plunge into ice water and blend into a smooth green puree. Heat oil in a pan and sauté chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste until golden. Add chopped tomatoes, green chilies, and salt, cooking until soft. Pour in the spinach puree and simmer for 5 minutes. Gently slide in paneer cubes, stir in garam masala, and finish with a swirl of heavy cream.

Substitutions: Tofu can replace paneer; soak cashews and blend with spinach if cream is missing.

Recipe: Quick Egg Biryani

Ingredients: basmati rice, eggs, onions, yogurt, biryani masala, mint leaves, saffron milk, ghee, salt

Instructions: Cook basmati rice until 90% done. Hard-boil eggs and fry with a pinch of turmeric. Fry sliced onions until dark brown and crispy (b barista). In a pot, mix yogurt, biryani masala, salt, some fried onions, and the eggs, cooking for 3 minutes. Layer the cooked rice over this egg base, top with remaining fried onions, mint leaves, saffron milk, and ghee. Cover tightly and steam (dum) on low heat for 10 minutes.

Substitutions: Use store-bought fried onions to speed up the process; skip saffron milk if unavailable.

Recipe: Sambar Express

Ingredients: yellow pigeon peas, mixed vegetables, tamarind paste, sambar powder, mustard seeds, curry leaves, asafoetida, oil, salt

Instructions: Boil toor dal until mushy. Boil mixed vegetables (drumsticks, carrots, pumpkins) in water with turmeric and salt. Add the boiled dal and tamarind paste to the vegetables. Stir in 2 tablespoons of sambar powder and simmer for 10 minutes. For tempering, heat oil, splutter mustard seeds, curry leaves, and a pinch of asafoetida, then pour directly into the bubbling sambar.

Substitutions: Use any local vegetables available; lemon juice can replace tamarind paste if needed.

Recipe: Malvani Chicken Sukka

Ingredients: chicken, grated coconut, fennel seeds, dry red chilies, onions, ginger-garlic paste, oil, salt

Instructions: Dry roast grated coconut, fennel seeds, and dry red chilies, then grind into a thick spice paste. Heat oil, fry plenty of chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste until brown, then add chicken and salt. Cover and let the chicken cook completely in its own juices. Once tender, stir in the coconut paste and roast uncovered until the curry dries out into a rich dish.

Substitutions: Use desiccated coconut if fresh coconut is missing; adjust red chilies for spice control.

Recipe: Gujarati Kadhi

Ingredients: yogurt, gram flour, ginger-green chili paste, sugar, mustard seeds, cloves, cinnamon, ghee, curry leaves, salt

Instructions: Whisk yogurt, gram flour (besan), water, and salt into a lump-free liquid. Bring to a boil in a pot, stirring constantly so it does not split, then simmer on low heat for 10 minutes. Add ginger-green chili paste and sugar. Heat ghee, fry mustard seeds, curry leaves, a clove, and a small cinnamon stick, pouring this aromatic tempering into the sweet-tangy simmering kadhi.

Substitutions: Jaggery can replace white sugar; regular oil can replace ghee for tempering.

Recipe: Simple Methi Chaman

Ingredients: paneer, fresh fenugreek leaves, spinach, onions, ginger-garlic paste, garam masala, oil, salt

Instructions: Blanch and puree equal parts fenugreek (methi) leaves and spinach. Heat oil, sauté chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste, then add the green puree and salt. Simmer for 7 minutes until the raw smell of methi disappears. Add paneer cubes and garam masala, stirring gently on low heat for 3 minutes before serving with flatbreads.

Substitutions: Use only spinach and a spoonful of kasuri methi if fresh fenugreek leaves are too bitter.

Recipe: Homestyle Fish Amritsari

Ingredients: fish fillets, gram flour, carom seeds, ginger-garlic paste, lemon juice, chili powder, oil, salt

Instructions: Cut firm fish into bite-sized strips. Marinate with ginger-garlic paste, lemon juice, chili powder, carom seeds (ajwain), and salt. Dust the fish with gram flour (besan) and a splash of water to form a thick coating. Deep-fry the coated fish pieces in hot oil until golden brown and exceptionally crispy. Serve hot sprinkled with chat masala.

Substitutions: Boneless chicken strips can be fried using the exact same spice and batter configuration.

Recipe: Kashmiri Dum Olav (Alou)

Ingredients: baby potatoes, Kashmiri chili powder, fennel powder, ginger powder, yogurt, mustard oil, salt

Instructions: Boil, peel, and prick baby potatoes, then deep-fry in mustard oil until golden brown. Whisk yogurt with Kashmiri chili powder, fennel powder, and dry ginger powder. Heat 2 tablespoons of oil, pour in the spiced yogurt mixture on low heat, stirring rapidly. Slide in the fried potatoes, add a half-cup of water, cover tightly, and simmer on low heat for 12 minutes until the gravy thickens.

Substitutions: Regular cooking oil can replace mustard oil; use large potatoes cut into rounds if baby potatoes are missing.

Recipe: Quick Masala Khichdi

Ingredients: rice, yellow moong dal, mixed vegetables, onions, tomatoes, cumin seeds, turmeric, oil, salt, water

Instructions: Wash rice and moong dal together. Heat oil or ghee in a pressure cooker, crackle cumin seeds, and sauté chopped onions, tomatoes, and diced vegetables for 2 minutes. Stir in turmeric, chili powder, and salt. Add the rice, dal, and 4 cups of water. Close the cooker lid and cook for 3 to 4 whistles until completely soft, mushy, and comforting.

Substitutions: Omit vegetables for a plain simple khichdi; serve with a dollop of fresh ghee.

Recipe: Cheesy Paneer Tikka (Pan Style)

Ingredients: paneer, bell peppers, onions, yogurt, ginger-garlic paste, tikka masala powder, butter, salt

Instructions: Cut paneer, bell peppers, and onions into large cubes. Marinate them in a mixture of thick yogurt, ginger-garlic paste, tikka masala powder, oil, and salt for 30 minutes. Heat butter in a non-stick skillet and sear the marinated paneer and vegetable cubes on high heat for 2 minutes per side until charred spots appear.

Substitutions: Use a kitchen skewer to grill over an open flame; substitute paneer with firm tofu cubes.

Recipe: Simple Egg Korma

Ingredients: hard-boiled eggs, onions, cashews, yogurt, garlic, garam masala, oil, salt

Instructions: Hard-boil and peel eggs, slicing them in half. Fry sliced onions until golden brown, then blend with cashews and yogurt into a smooth paste. Heat oil, sauté minced garlic, add the rich onion-cashew paste, turmeric, and salt, simmering for 5 minutes. Gently lay the egg halves into the rich gravy, sprinkle garam masala, and simmer covered for 4 minutes.

Substitutions: Almonds can replace cashews; add a splash of milk if the korma gravy turns out too thick.

Recipe: Sindhi Sai Bhaji

Ingredients: spinach, chana dal, potatoes, carrots, onions, tomatoes, ginger, green chilies, oil, salt

Instructions: Soak chana dal for 30 minutes. In a pressure cooker, combine chopped spinach, soaked dal, diced potatoes, carrots, onions, tomatoes, minced ginger, green chilies, water, and salt. Cook for 4 whistles until everything is soft. Open and mash the contents thoroughly with a wooden churner. Top with a tempering of fried garlic in ghee.

Substitutions: Use any green leafy vegetables along with spinach; regular oil can replace ghee.

Recipe: Mughlai Chicken Rezala Quick

Ingredients: chicken, onion paste, yogurt, cashew paste, garlic, dry red chilies, kewra water, ghee, salt

Instructions: Marinate chicken with yogurt, onion paste, and minced garlic for 30 minutes. Heat ghee in a pot, fry dry red chilies, then add the marinated chicken and salt, cooking on medium heat for 10 minutes. Stir in cashew paste and a half-cup of water, simmering covered for 15 minutes until the chicken is tender. Stir in a drop of kewra water before serving.

Substitutions: Regular rose water can replace kewra water; adjust cashew paste to control grease levels.

Recipe: Mangalorean Prawn Ghee Roast

Ingredients: prawns, ghee, dry red chilies, coriander seeds, cumin seeds, garlic, tamarind paste, salt

Instructions: Dry roast red chilies, coriander, and cumin seeds, blending with garlic and tamarind into a smooth paste. Marinate prawns with turmeric and salt. Heat a generous pool of ghee in a pan, fry the spice paste until oil separates, then toss in the prawns. Cook on high heat for 4 to 5 minutes until the prawns are glazed and cooked through.

Substitutions: Chicken pieces can be cooked in this manner but take longer to roast than prawns.

Recipe: Easy Veg Makhanwala

Ingredients: carrots, peas, French beans, paneer, tomato puree, butter, heavy cream, kasuri methi, sugar, salt

Instructions: Boil mixed vegetables until tender. Heat butter in a pan, add tomato puree, sugar, and salt, cooking for 5 minutes. Stir in the boiled vegetables, paneer cubes, and a half-cup of water, simmering for 5 minutes. Turn the heat down, mix in heavy cream and a handful of crushed kasuri methi, and remove from heat.

Substitutions: Use regular milk mixed with a teaspoon of cornstarch if heavy cream is unavailable.

Recipe: Punjabi Black Dal (Dal Makhani Quick)

Ingredients: whole black lentils, kidney beans, tomato puree, ginger-garlic paste, butter, cream, chili powder, salt

Instructions: Pressure cook soaked black lentils (urad dal) and kidney beans (rajma) with water and salt until completely mashed. Heat butter in a pot, fry ginger-garlic paste, then add tomato puree and chili powder,

cooking for 5 minutes. Pour in the cooked dals, mashing them with a heavy spoon while simmering on low heat for 20 minutes. Stir in heavy cream and extra butter.

Substitutions: Simmering longer improves taste, but a quick 20-minute cook still works fine with enough butter.

Recipe: Simple Chicken Jalfrezi

Ingredients: chicken, bell peppers, onions, tomato ketchup, vinegar, soy sauce, ginger, oil, salt

Instructions: Slice chicken, bell peppers, and onions into long thin strips. Heat oil in a pan, stir-fry chicken strips and minced ginger on high heat for 5 minutes until cooked. Toss in the bell pepper and onion strips, cooking for 2 minutes. Pour in tomato ketchup, vinegar, soy sauce, and salt, tossing rapidly on high heat until glazed.

Substitutions: Add red chili flakes for heat; replace chicken with paneer strips for a vegetarian variant.

Recipe: Andhra Tomato Pappu

Ingredients: yellow pigeon peas, tomatoes, onions, green chilies, tamarind, mustard seeds, curry leaves, oil, salt

Instructions: Pressure cook yellow lentils (toor dal) with chopped tomatoes, onions, green chilies, and turmeric until soft. Mash the dal gently, add tamarind juice and salt, and simmer on the stove for 5 minutes. Heat oil in a tiny pan, splutter mustard seeds and curry leaves, and pour this hot tempering over the bubbling tomato dal.

Substitutions: Use lemon juice instead of tamarind juice; adjust green chilies depending on spice preference.

Recipe: Quick Chicken Keema Matar

Ingredients: minced chicken, green peas, onions, tomatoes, ginger-garlic paste, garam masala, oil, salt

Instructions: Heat oil, fry chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste until brown, then sauté chopped tomatoes until soft. Add minced chicken (keema), green peas, turmeric, chili powder, and salt. Stir continuously on high heat for 5 minutes to break up clumps. Lower heat, cover, and cook for 10 minutes until chicken mince is done.

Substitutions: Minced turkey can be used; omit green peas if you prefer a pure meat transition.

Recipe: Malabar Spinach Dal (Cheera Parippu)

Ingredients: yellow moong dal, spinach, grated coconut, cumin seeds, green chilies, mustard seeds, oil, salt

Instructions: Boil moong dal until soft. Grind fresh grated coconut, cumin seeds, and green chilies into a smooth paste. Add chopped spinach and the coconut paste to the boiled dal, cooking for 5 minutes until the spinach wilts. Temper by heating oil, popping mustard seeds and sliced shallots, and mixing into the hot dal.

Substitutions: Toor dal can replace moong dal; use dried red chilies in the tempering for extra visual look.

Recipe: Easy Rajasthani Gatte Ki Sabzi

Ingredients: gram flour, yogurt, carom seeds, chili powder, turmeric, mustard seeds, oil, salt, water

Instructions: Mix gram flour (besan), carom seeds, chili powder, a tablespoon of oil, and yogurt into a stiff dough; roll into long cylinders. Boil these cylinders in water for 10 minutes, cut into small round pieces (gatte), and save the water. Whisk yogurt with turmeric and chili powder. Heat oil, fry mustard seeds, add the yogurt mix on low heat, then pour in the gatte and saved boiling water, simmering for 10 minutes.

Substitutions: Store-bought readymade gatte can save dough preparation time; adjust yogurt for sourness.

Recipe: Homestyle Egg Masala Dry

Ingredients: hard-boiled eggs, onions, tomatoes, curry leaves, black pepper, turmeric, oil, salt

Instructions: Cut boiled eggs into halves. Heat oil, fry chopped onions and curry leaves until brown, then add chopped tomatoes, turmeric, and salt, cooking until dry. Push the onion-tomato mix to the side, place the egg halves cut-side down in the pan, sear for 2 minutes, flip, and coat heavily with the dry savory onion base.

Substitutions: Add fennel seeds to the oil for a South Indian touch; use chili powder instead of pepper.

Recipe: Simple Vegetable Jalfrezi

Ingredients: carrots, bell peppers, baby corn, onions, tomato sauce, vinegar, soy sauce, oil, salt

Instructions: Cut all vegetables into long thin strips. Heat oil in a wide skillet, sauté onions and carrots for 3 minutes, then add bell peppers and baby corn, stir-frying on high heat to keep them crunchy. Stir in tomato sauce, vinegar, soy sauce, and salt, tossing rapidly for 2 minutes until every vegetable strip is glazed.

Substitutions: Add paneer or tofu strips; use fresh green chilies if you want an extra spicy bite.

Recipe: Quick Chicken Saagwala

Ingredients: chicken, spinach, onions, tomatoes, ginger-garlic paste, garam masala, oil, salt

Instructions: Blanch spinach and blend into a smooth puree. Heat oil, fry chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste until brown, then add chopped tomatoes and salt, cooking until mushy. Add chicken pieces, searing them on high heat for 5 minutes. Pour in the spinach puree, cover, and simmer on medium-low heat for 15 minutes until chicken is tender.

Substitutions: Chicken boneless breast cubes work best; add a spoonful of butter at the end for flavor.

Recipe: Easy Goan Fish Curry

Ingredients: fish fillets, coconut milk, tamarind paste, turmeric, coriander powder, cumin powder, garlic, oil, salt

Instructions: Marinate fish with turmeric and salt. In a bowl, mix thick coconut milk with tamarind paste, coriander powder, cumin powder, and minced garlic. Heat oil in a pan, pour in the spiced coconut milk mixture, and bring to a very gentle simmer. Slide in the fish fillets, cover, and cook on low heat for 7 to 8 minutes until done.

Substitutions: Any firm white fish or prawns can be used; swap tamarind with kokum if available.

Recipe: Bengali Alur Dom Express

Ingredients: potatoes, tomato puree, ginger paste, cumin powder, garam masala, mustard oil, salt, water

Instructions: Boil potatoes, peel them, and cut into large chunks; fry in mustard oil until golden. In the same oil, sauté ginger paste and tomato puree, then add cumin powder, turmeric, and salt, cooking for 3 minutes. Pour in a half-cup of water and the fried potatoes, simmering covered on medium-low heat for 10 minutes until thick.

Substitutions: Regular cooking oil can replace mustard oil; add green peas for a nice contrast.

Recipe: Quick Matar Mushroom Curry

Ingredients: mushrooms, green peas, onions, tomatoes, ginger-garlic paste, garam masala, oil, salt

Instructions: Slice mushrooms. Heat oil, fry chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste until golden, then add chopped tomatoes, turmeric, chili powder, and salt, cooking until soft. Toss in the mushrooms and green peas, stirring for 2 minutes. Cover and cook on medium-low heat for 8 minutes; mushrooms will release their own gravy.

Substitutions: Canned mushrooms save washing time; add a splash of milk for a creamier finish.

Recipe: Simple Chicken Podimas (Shredded Chicken)

Ingredients: chicken breast, onions, green chilies, curry leaves, black pepper, turmeric, oil, salt

Instructions: Boil chicken breast with turmeric and salt, then shred the meat using two forks. Heat oil in a skillet, fry curry leaves, chopped onions, and green chilies until golden. Add the shredded chicken and salt, stir-frying on medium-high heat for 4 minutes. Sprinkle a large spoonful of black pepper powder and serve dry.

Substitutions: Use leftover roasted chicken to skip boiling steps; swap green chilies with red chili flakes.

Recipe: Easy Paneer Do Pyaza

Ingredients: paneer, onions, tomatoes, ginger-garlic paste, garam masala, oil, salt

Instructions: Cut paneer into cubes. Cut onions into two styles: finely chopped and large petals. Heat oil, sauté the onion petals for 1 minute and set aside. In the same oil, fry the chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste, add chopped tomatoes and salt, cooking until soft. Add paneer, garam masala, and fried onion petals, simmering for 4 minutes.

Substitutions: Use tofu cubes instead of paneer; add a tablespoon of yogurt to thicken the masala gravy.

Recipe: Quick Chana Masala (Canned)

Ingredients: canned chickpeas, onions, tomatoes, ginger-garlic paste, amchur, garam masala, oil, salt

Instructions: Heat oil, fry chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste until brown, then add chopped tomatoes, turmeric, and chili powder, cooking until soft. Drain canned chickpeas and add to the pan along with a half-cup of water, amchur (dry mango powder), and salt. Simmer uncovered for 10 minutes, mashing some chickpeas to create texture.

Substitutions: Use chat masala instead of amchur powder; garnish with fresh ginger matchsticks.

Recipe: Simple Bhindi Do Pyaza

Ingredients: okra, onions, turmeric, red chili powder, amchur, oil, salt

Instructions: Wash and dry okra, cutting into one-inch pieces. Slice onions into large petals. Heat oil, fry the onion petals for 2 minutes until translucent; remove. In the same pan, fry the okra uncovered for 8 minutes until stickiness is gone. Stir in the fried onions, turmeric, chili powder, amchur, and salt, cooking for 3 more minutes.

Substitutions: Use lemon juice if amchur is unavailable; omit onions for a plain simple bhindi bhaji finish.

Recipe: Easy Egg Kolhapuri

Ingredients: hard-boiled eggs, onions, tomatoes, ginger-garlic paste, Kolhapuri masala, oil, salt, water

Instructions: Cut boiled eggs in half. Heat oil, fry chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste until dark brown, then add chopped tomatoes and cook until soft. Stir in a tablespoon of Kolhapuri masala powder and salt.

Pour in a half-cup of water, bring the spicy gravy to a boil, slide in the eggs, and simmer covered for 5 minutes.

Substitutions: Use regular garam masala and extra red chili powder if authentic Kolhapuri masala is missing.

Recipe: Quick Chicken Kadhai Express

Ingredients: chicken, bell peppers, onions, tomatoes, ginger-garlic paste, kadhai masala, oil, salt

Instructions: Cube chicken, bell peppers, and onions. Heat oil, fry chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste, then add chopped tomatoes and cook into a paste. Add chicken and kadhai masala powder, searing on high heat for 5 minutes. Toss in the bell pepper and onion cubes, cover, and cook on medium heat for 12 minutes until done.

Substitutions: Boneless chicken breast cubes work best; adjust kadhai masala depending on heat tolerance.

Recipe: Simple Methi Matar Malai

Ingredients: fresh fenugreek leaves, green peas, heavy cream, onions, ginger-green chili paste, oil, salt

Instructions: Chop fenugreek (methi) leaves and sauté in oil for 2 minutes to reduce bitterness; set aside. Heat oil, fry chopped onions and ginger-green chili paste until soft, then add green peas and a splash of water, cooking for 5 minutes. Stir in the methi leaves, salt, and a generous half-cup of heavy cream, simmering on low heat for 3 minutes.

Substitutions: Milk mixed with a little cornstarch can replace heavy cream; use sugar to balance bitterness.

Recipe: Easy Veg Kolhapuri Express

Ingredients: carrots, peas, beans, cauliflowers, onions, tomatoes, Kolhapuri masala, oil, salt

Instructions: Chop vegetables and boil until tender. Heat oil, fry chopped onions, tomatoes, and ginger-garlic paste until mushy. Add a tablespoon of spicy Kolhapuri masala powder and salt. Toss in the boiled vegetables and a half-cup of water, simmering uncovered on medium-high heat for 8 minutes until the gravy is thick and fiery.

Substitutions: Add paneer or mushroom pieces; adjust spice levels by adding a spoonful of cream if too hot.

Recipe: Quick Chicken Achari

Ingredients: chicken, achari masala, yogurt, onions, ginger-garlic paste, oil, salt

Instructions: Marinate chicken with yogurt and salt. Heat oil, crackle achari masala seeds (mustard, fennel, cumin, fenugreek, onion seeds), then fry chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste. Add the marinated chicken, cooking on high heat for 5 minutes. Lower heat, cover, and let it simmer in its own juices for 15 minutes until tender.

Substitutions: Use a spoonful of regular mango pickle gravy if you don't have whole achari spices on hand.

Recipe: Simple Jeera Aloo Matar

Ingredients: potatoes, green peas, cumin seeds, turmeric, chili powder, oil, salt

Instructions: Boil, peel, and cube potatoes. Heat oil, add a large tablespoon of whole cumin seeds (jeera) until brown. Toss in the potato cubes and green peas. Add turmeric powder, red chili powder, and salt. Stir-fry gently on medium-high heat for 6 minutes until the potatoes develop a crispy golden exterior skin.

Substitutions: Ghee gives a richer taste than oil; use frozen peas to eliminate separate boiling steps.

Recipe: Easy Fish Moilee (Kerala Style)

Ingredients: fish fillets, coconut milk, turmeric, ginger, green chilies, curry leaves, oil, salt

Instructions: Marinate fish with turmeric, lemon juice, and salt. Heat oil, fry curry leaves, thin ginger matchsticks, and slit green chilies for 1 minute. Pour in thin coconut milk and bring to a bare simmer. Slide in the fish fillets and cook covered on low heat for 6 minutes. Turn heat off, stir in thick coconut milk, and serve.

Substitutions: Prawns can replace fish fillets; regular cooking oil can replace coconut oil if preferred.

Recipe: Quick Chicken White Korma

Ingredients: chicken, onions, cashews, yogurt, ginger-garlic paste, garam masala, oil, salt

Instructions: Whisk yogurt with cashew paste. Heat oil, fry chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste until soft but pale (do not brown). Add chicken pieces and sear for 4 minutes. Turn heat to low, pour in the yogurt-cashew mixture and salt, stirring continuously. Cover and simmer gently for 15 minutes until chicken is cooked.

Substitutions: Almond paste can replace cashew paste; use white pepper instead of black pepper to maintain white color.

Recipe: Simple Baingan Fry (Tawa Style)

Ingredients: eggplants, turmeric, red chili powder, gram flour, oil, salt

Instructions: Slice a large eggplant into round discs. In a plate, mix turmeric powder, red chili powder, salt, and a tablespoon of gram flour (besan). Coat both sides of the eggplant discs thoroughly with this dry spice mix. Heat oil on a tawa or flat frying pan and shallow-fry the discs for 3 minutes per side until soft inside and crispy outside.

Substitutions: Rice flour can replace gram flour for a crunchier bite; adjust chili powder to taste.

Recipe: Quick Chicken Mughlai Curry

Ingredients: chicken, onions, tomato puree, eggs, ginger-garlic paste, garam masala, cream, oil, salt

Instructions: Heat oil, fry chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste until brown, then add tomato puree, turmeric, and chili powder. Add chicken and salt, searing for 5 minutes. Pour in a half-cup of water, cover, and cook for 12 minutes. Whisk an egg and drizzle it slowly into the hot curry, stirring rapidly to form rich threads. Finish with a spoonful of cream.

Substitutions: Omit the egg drizzle if you prefer a standard creamy gravy style; boneless chicken works best.

Recipe: Easy Aloo Baingan Sukha

Ingredients: potatoes, eggplants, onions, tomatoes, turmeric, coriander powder, oil, salt

Instructions: Cube potatoes and eggplants into equal sizes. Heat oil, fry chopped onions until soft, then add chopped tomatoes, turmeric, coriander powder, and salt, cooking until mushy. Toss in the potato and eggplant cubes, mixing well. Cover the pan with a tight lid and let it cook on low heat for 15 minutes until tender.

Substitutions: Pan-fry potatoes first to reduce overall steaming time; swap coriander powder with chat masala.

Recipe: Quick Chicken Pepper Fry (Dry)

Ingredients: chicken, onions, black pepper powder, curry leaves, ginger-garlic paste, oil, salt

Instructions: Heat oil, fry plenty of curry leaves, chopped onions, and ginger-garlic paste until deep golden brown. Add chicken boneless cubes and salt, stir-frying on high heat for 5 minutes to lock in juices. Turn

heat to medium-low, cover, and cook for 10 minutes. Remove lid, add a large tablespoon of crushed black pepper, and roast until completely dry. Substitutions: Use chicken wings or drumsticks instead of boneless cubes; adjust pepper for spice control.

Recipe: Simple Dal Palak Quick

Ingredients: yellow split lentils, spinach, garlic, cumin seeds, turmeric, oil, salt

Instructions: Pressure cook yellow moong dal with water and turmeric until soft. Heat oil in a pan, crackle cumin seeds, and fry a large amount of chopped garlic until golden. Add chopped fresh spinach leaves, cooking for 2 minutes until wilted. Pour the boiled dal and salt into the spinach pan, stir thoroughly, and boil for 2 minutes.

Substitutions: Toor dal or masoor dal can replace moong dal; add green chilies along with garlic for heat.

Recipe: Easy Paneer Jalfrezi Quick

Ingredients: paneer, bell peppers, onions, tomatoes, tomato ketchup, vinegar, oil, salt

Instructions: Slice paneer, bell peppers, and onions into long strips. Heat oil, sauté onion and pepper strips for 2 minutes on high heat to keep them crunchy. Toss in the paneer strips. Stir in tomato ketchup, a splash of vinegar, chili powder, and salt, tossing rapidly over high heat for 1 minute until glazed and hot.

Substitutions: Use tofu strips for a dairy-free recipe layout; swap ketchup with fresh tomato puree if preferred.

Recipe: Quick Chicken Tikka Masala Express

Ingredients: chicken cubes, tomato puree, onions, ginger-garlic paste, tikka masala powder, cream, butter, salt

Instructions: Sauté chicken cubes in a pan with butter until cooked and browned; set aside. In the same pan, fry chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste, add tomato puree, tikka masala powder, and salt, cooking for 5 minutes. Slide the cooked chicken back into the sauce, simmer for 3 minutes, and stir in a spoonful of heavy cream.

Substitutions: Use store-bought pre-cooked grilled chicken pieces to cut down preparation time massively.

Recipe: Simple Lauki Chana Dal

Ingredients: bottle gourd, chana dal, onions, tomatoes, cumin seeds, turmeric, oil, salt

Instructions: Soak chana dal for 30 minutes. Peel and cube bottle gourd (lauki). In a pressure cooker, heat oil, crackle cumin seeds, and fry chopped onions and tomatoes. Add turmeric, chili powder, lauki cubes, soaked chana dal, salt, and a half-cup of water. Close cooker and cook for 3 whistles until the dal is tender but holds shape.

Substitutions: Cook in an open pot if you prefer a less mushy consistency, though it takes double the time.

Recipe: Easy Chicken Handi Quick

Ingredients: chicken, onions, tomato puree, yogurt, ginger-garlic paste, garam masala, butter, salt

Instructions: Heat oil and butter in a pot, fry chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste until brown, then add tomato puree and cook for 3 minutes. Add chicken pieces, turmeric, chili powder, and salt, searing for 5 minutes. Whisk yogurt and stir in on low heat. Cover and cook on medium-low for 15 minutes until the chicken is tender.

Substitutions: Cook in a clay pot (handi) for an authentic earthy scent; add cashews to thicken gravy.

Recipe: Quick Matar Aloo Chaat

Ingredients: potatoes, frozen peas, onions, chat masala, lemon juice, green chutney, salt

Instructions: Boil, peel, and cube potatoes. Toss the potato cubes and thawed green peas in a bowl. Add finely chopped raw onions, a generous tablespoon of chat masala powder, salt, a drizzle of spicy green mint chutney, and fresh lemon juice. Mix thoroughly until every potato cube is coated in the tangy street-style dressing.

Substitutions: Sweet potatoes can replace regular potatoes; add sweet tamarind chutney for a sweet contrast.

Recipe: Simple Egg Pulao Express

Ingredients: basmati rice, hard-boiled eggs, onions, cumin seeds, turmeric, oil, water, salt

Instructions: Wash and soak basmati rice for 15 minutes. Heat oil in a pot, crackle cumin seeds, and fry sliced onions until golden. Add turmeric powder, salt, the soaked rice, and water, bringing to a boil. Place whole hard-boiled eggs gently into the liquid, cover tightly, turn heat to low, and cook for 12 minutes until fluffy.

Substitutions: Regular white short-grain rice can replace basmati; serve with a side of cool onion raita.

Recipe: Classic Mint Cilantro Chutney

Ingredients: mint leaves, cilantro, green chilies, ginger, lemon juice, salt, water

Instructions: Thoroughly wash equal parts fresh mint leaves and cilantro (including tender stems). Place them in a blender along with green chilies, a small piece of ginger, fresh lemon juice, and salt. Add a minimal splash of cold water (cold water helps retain the bright green color). Blend on high speed until completely smooth and paste-like. Pour into a bowl and serve with snacks.

Substitutions: Add a tablespoon of roasted chana dal or yogurt to give the chutney a thicker, creamier structure.

Recipe: Quick Coconut Chutney

Ingredients: grated coconut, roasted chana dal, green chilies, ginger, mustard seeds, curry leaves, oil, salt, water

Instructions: In a blender, combine fresh grated coconut, a tablespoon of roasted chana dal (dalia), green chilies, ginger, salt, and water, blending into a smooth paste. Transfer to a bowl. For the tempering, heat a teaspoon of oil in a tiny pan, splutter mustard seeds, and fry curry leaves until crisp. Pour this hot oil tempering directly onto the coconut paste and mix well.

Substitutions: Dried red chilies can be added to the tempering; use warm water if blending frozen coconut.

Recipe: Tangy Tamarind Jaggery Chutney

Ingredients: tamarind paste, jaggery, cumin powder, ginger powder, salt, water

Instructions: In a small saucepan, combine tamarind paste, crushed jaggery, and water, bringing the mixture to a gentle boil over medium heat. Stir continuously until the jaggery melts completely and the sauce thickens slightly to a pourable syrup consistency. Stir in roasted cumin powder, dry ginger powder (sonth), and salt. Simmer for 2 more minutes, then remove from heat and let cool completely.

Substitutions: Use dates along with tamarind to create a classic sweet-and-sour date-tamarind chutney configuration.

Recipe: Instant Ginger Pickles

Ingredients: ginger, lemon juice, salt

Instructions: Peel fresh ginger roots and slice them into very thin, long matchsticks (juliennes). Place the ginger matchsticks inside a clean, dry glass jar. Sprinkle generously with salt and pour in fresh lemon juice until the ginger pieces are completely submerged. Close the lid tightly and shake well. Within an hour, the chemical reaction will turn the ginger pieces a beautiful bright pink color. Store in the fridge.

Substitutions: Add a few slit green chilies into the jar along with the ginger for an extra spicy pickle kick.

Recipe: Spicy Garlic Chutney (Dry)

Ingredients: garlic, desiccated coconut, red chili powder, peanuts, salt, oil

Instructions: Heat a teaspoon of oil in a pan and lightly roast whole peeled garlic cloves and peanuts until golden; remove. In the same pan, toss desiccated coconut powder for 1 minute until fragrant. Combine the roasted garlic, peanuts, coconut, a large amount of red chili powder, and salt in a dry spice grinder, pulsing briefly until it forms a coarse, sandy powder. Do not over-blend, or it will turn into a paste.

Substitutions: This is the classic dry chutney used for Vada Pav; adjust red chili powder to control color and heat.

Recipe: Roasted Peanut Chutney

Ingredients: peanuts, green chilies, garlic, tamarind, oil, mustard seeds, curry leaves, salt, water

Instructions: Dry roast peanuts in a pan until the skins loosen and turn brown; peel them. Blend the roasted peanuts with green chilies, garlic, a small piece of tamarind, salt, and water into a thick, smooth paste. Pour into a bowl. Heat a little oil, crackle mustard seeds and curry leaves, and pour this hot tempering over the peanut paste.

Substitutions: Use lemon juice if tamarind is missing; add a splash of milk for a whiter chutney color.

Recipe: Simple Onion Tomato Chutney

Ingredients: onions, tomatoes, dry red chilies, garlic, oil, mustard seeds, salt

Instructions: Heat oil in a pan and sauté sliced onions, chopped garlic, and dry red chilies until the onions turn translucent. Add chopped tomatoes and salt, cooking until soft. Let the mixture cool down completely, then blend into a smooth paste without adding water. Temper the chutney by heating a teaspoon of oil, popping mustard seeds, and stirring them in.

Substitutions: Use green chilies instead of red chilies if you prefer a different heat element and lighter color.

Recipe: Instant Raw Mango Pickle

Ingredients: raw mango, mustard seeds, fenugreek powder, red chili powder, turmeric powder, mustard oil, salt

Instructions: Wash and completely dry a raw green mango, then chop it into tiny, even cubes. Place the mango cubes in a bowl, add a generous amount of salt, red chili powder, turmeric powder, and a tiny pinch of roasted fenugreek powder. Heat mustard oil in a small pan until it smokes, let it cool down slightly, and pour it over the spiced mango pieces, mixing thoroughly until coated.

Substitutions: Regular neutral vegetable oil can replace mustard oil; add carom seeds if you like their flavor.

Recipe: Sweet Tomato Chutney (Bengali Style)

Ingredients: tomatoes, panch phoron, dry red chili, ginger, sugar, raisins, oil, salt

Instructions: Heat oil in a pan, add a pinch of panch phoron and a dry red chili. Add chopped tomatoes and salt, cooking on medium heat until the tomatoes turn soft and mushy. Stir in sugar and finely grated ginger, letting the sugar melt completely and simmer into a thick, sticky syrup. Toss in raisins and simmer for 3 minutes until glossy.

Substitutions: Jaggery can replace white sugar; add date pieces along with raisins for richness.

Recipe: Simple Sesame Chutney (Til Chutney)

Ingredients: sesame seeds, garlic, green chilies, lemon juice, salt, water

Instructions: Dry roast white sesame seeds (til) in a pan on low heat for 3 to 4 minutes until they turn a light golden color and start popping; let them cool. Blend the roasted sesame seeds with garlic cloves, green chilies, salt, fresh lemon juice, and water into a smooth, thick dipping paste. Serve alongside steamed snacks.

Substitutions: Use black sesame seeds for a visually striking dark chutney; swap lemon juice with tamarind.

Recipe: Green Chili Pickle Quick

Ingredients: green chilies, mustard seeds powder, turmeric powder, lemon juice, oil, salt

Instructions: Wash green chilies and dry them completely. Slit them down the center without cutting them in half. In a small bowl, mix mustard seed powder (rai kuria), turmeric powder, oil, and salt into a thick paste. Stuff this mustard paste inside the slit green chilies. Arrange the stuffed chilies in a jar and pour fresh lemon juice over them. Substitutions: Let it sit in the sun for 1 day to develop deep tangy flavors rapidly; use any cooking oil.

Recipe: Easy Coriander Stem Chutney

Ingredients: coriander stems, green chilies, garlic, cumin seeds, lemon juice, salt

Instructions: Instead of discarding coriander stems, wash them thoroughly to remove dirt. Chop them coarsely and place in a small blender jar along with green chilies, garlic cloves, cumin seeds, salt, and fresh lemon juice. Blend into a thick, smooth, highly aromatic green paste, using minimal water.

Substitutions: This is an excellent zero-waste recipe; add a few mint leaves if you have them on hand.

Recipe: Curry Leaf Spice Powder (Karuveppilai Podi)

Ingredients: curry leaves, urad dal, chana dal, dry red chilies, oil, salt

Instructions: Wash curry leaves and dry them completely on a towel. Heat a teaspoon of oil in a pan, roast urad dal and chana dal until deep golden brown, then add dry red chilies and remove. In the same pan, roast the dry curry leaves on low heat until they turn completely crisp and brittle. Grind the roasted dals, red chilies, curry leaves, and salt into a coarse powder.

Substitutions: Serve this flavorful spice powder mixed with hot rice and a spoonful of melted ghee.

Recipe: Tangy Yogurt Dip (Perugu Pachadi)

Ingredients: yogurt, cucumbers, mustard seeds, green chilies, curry leaves, oil, salt

Instructions: Whisk thick yogurt with salt in a bowl. Grate cucumber, squeeze out excess water, and stir into the yogurt. Heat a teaspoon of oil, splutter mustard seeds, and fry chopped green chilies and curry leaves. Pour this hot tempering over the cold cucumber-yogurt mixture and stir well before serving.

Substitutions: Grated carrots or boiled beetroot can replace cucumber to create colorful variations.

Recipe: Simple Ginger Garlic Paste Base

Ingredients: ginger, garlic, oil, salt

Instructions: Peel equal weights of fresh ginger root and garlic cloves. Chop the ginger into small pieces. Place the ginger and garlic into a clean blender jar. Add a tablespoon of oil and a teaspoon of salt (oil and salt act as natural preservatives). Blend on high speed, scraping down the sides, until a perfectly smooth, thick paste forms. Store in an airtight glass jar in the refrigerator.

Substitutions: Use a splash of vinegar instead of oil if planning to store it for more than a month.

Recipe: Perfect Basmati Rice

Ingredients: basmati rice, water, salt, ghee

Instructions: Wash the basmati rice multiple times until the water runs clear to remove surface starch, then soak in fresh water for 20 minutes; drain. Bring 2 cups of water and a pinch of salt to a rolling boil in a saucepan. Add the soaked rice and a teaspoon of ghee. Let it boil uncovered on medium-high heat until most of the water evaporates and small steam holes appear on the surface of the rice. Turn heat to lowest, cover tightly with a lid, and steam for 6 minutes. Fluff with a fork.

Substitutions: Omit ghee for a completely oil-free white rice option; add a pod of cardamom for mild scent.

Recipe: Simple Jeera Rice

Ingredients: basmati rice, cumin seeds, bay leaf, ghee, water, salt

Instructions: Wash and soak basmati rice for 15 minutes. Heat ghee in a pot, add a bay leaf and a generous tablespoon of whole cumin seeds (jeera), frying until they crackle and smell highly aromatic. Add the drained rice and stir gently for 1 minute to coat every grain in the spiced ghee. Pour in double the volume of water, add salt, and bring to a boil. Reduce heat to low, cover tightly with a lid, and cook for 12 minutes until water is completely absorbed.

Substitutions: Cooking oil can replace ghee; regular white short-grain rice can replace basmati.

Recipe: Homestyle Wheat Chapati

Ingredients: whole wheat flour, water, salt, oil

Instructions: Mix whole wheat flour and a pinch of salt in a wide bowl. Gradually add lukewarm water and knead thoroughly for 8 to 10 minutes to develop gluten, forming a soft, pliable dough. Drizzle a teaspoon of oil, knead once more, cover with a damp cloth, and rest for 20 minutes. Roll out small dough balls into thin, even circular discs. Cook on a medium-hot iron tawa until tiny bubbles appear, flip, and apply a small smear of oil or ghee, pressing edges until puffed.

Substitutions: Roll into squares or triangles to create an easy layered paratha layout instead.

Recipe: Quick Onion Raita

Ingredients: yogurt, onions, green chilies, roasted cumin powder, salt, cilantro

Instructions: Whisk plain yogurt in a mixing bowl until completely smooth and free of lumps. Add finely chopped raw onions and minced green chilies. Stir in a generous pinch of roasted cumin powder and salt. Mix thoroughly to combine the savory spice profile into the cool dairy base. Garnish with freshly chopped cilantro leaves and chill in the refrigerator for 10 minutes before serving alongside spicy biryanis or pulaos.

Substitutions: Add finely diced cucumbers or tomatoes to turn this into a mixed vegetable raita layout.

Recipe: Crispy Garlic Naan on Tawa

Ingredients: all-purpose flour, yogurt, baking powder, sugar, minced garlic, butter, water, salt

Instructions: Combine all-purpose flour (maida), a teaspoon of baking powder, sugar, salt, yogurt, and water, kneading into a soft dough; rest for 1 hour. Roll out oval shapes, and press a large amount of minced garlic into the top surface. Flip the naan over and brush the entire back surface generously with water. Place the wet side down onto a piping-hot iron tawa; it will stick. Flip the tawa upside down directly over the gas flame to char the garlic side. Scrape off and brush heavily with melted butter.

Substitutions: Whole wheat flour can replace maida, though the naan texture will turn out denser and less chewy.

Recipe: Simple Vegetable Pulao

Ingredients: basmati rice, mixed vegetables, onions, ginger-garlic paste, bay leaf, cinnamon, cardamom, oil, water, salt

Instructions: Wash and soak basmati rice for 15 minutes. Heat oil in a pot, fry a bay leaf, a small stick of cinnamon, and two cardamom pods until fragrant. Sauté sliced onions and ginger-garlic paste until translucent. Toss in mixed vegetables (carrots, peas, beans, potatoes) and stir for 2 minutes. Add the drained rice, water (1.5 cups water for 1 cup rice), and salt. Bring to a boil, cover with a tight lid, reduce heat to low, and cook for 12 minutes.

Substitutions: Use any frozen vegetable mix to shorten prep time; add fried bread croutons or cashews for garnish.

Recipe: Classic Lemon Rice

Ingredients: pre-cooked rice, lemon juice, mustard seeds, peanuts, turmeric powder, green chilies, curry leaves, oil, salt

Instructions: Use cold pre-cooked or leftover rice, breaking up any large clumps. Heat oil in a pan, add mustard seeds, peanuts, curry leaves, and sliced green chilies, frying until the peanuts turn crunchy and golden brown. Turn the heat down to low, stir in turmeric powder and salt, then immediately add the cold rice, tossing thoroughly until every grain turns a vibrant yellow color. Remove from heat and pour in fresh lemon juice, mixing well.

Substitutions: Roasted chana dal can be added along with peanuts for extra authentic crunch; adjust lemon to taste.

Recipe: Ajwain Paratha (Layered Flatbread)

Ingredients: whole wheat flour, carom seeds, ghee, salt, water

Instructions: Knead a smooth dough using whole wheat flour, water, and salt. Roll a ball of dough into a large thin circle. Brush a layer of melted ghee over the surface, and sprinkle salt and carom seeds (ajwain) evenly across it. Fold the dough circle like a paper fan, roll it into a tight spiral, and flatten it back down into a ball. Roll out this layered ball into a flatbread and cook on a hot tawa with ghee, pressing edges to reveal flaky layers.

Substitutions: Black pepper powder or red chili flakes can replace carom seeds for a spicy flavor alternative.

Recipe: Soothing Curd Rice

Ingredients: cooked rice, yogurt, milk, mustard seeds, green chilies, ginger, curry leaves, oil, salt

Instructions: Mash hot cooked white rice gently with a spoon, then let it cool down completely. Stir in fresh plain yogurt, a splash of cold milk (this keeps the rice from turning sour), and salt, mixing until creamy. Heat oil in a tiny pan, splutter mustard seeds, then fry minced ginger, chopped green chilies, and curry leaves. Pour this aromatic hot oil tempering directly over the creamy cold rice mixture, stirring well before serving.

Substitutions: Garnish with pomegranate seeds or grated carrots for a refreshing sweet contrast.

Recipe: Basic Methi Puri

Ingredients: whole wheat flour, kasuri methi, turmeric powder, oil, water, salt

Instructions: In a bowl, combine whole wheat flour, a large handful of dried fenugreek leaves (kasuri methi), turmeric powder, a pinch of red chili powder, a teaspoon of oil, and salt. Rub ingredients together, then

add water slowly, kneading into a very tight, hard dough; do not make it soft, or the puris will absorb too much oil. Roll out into small, thick circular discs. Deep-fry in smoking-hot oil, pressing gently with a slotted spoon until they puff up completely like balls.
Substitutions: Fresh finely chopped fenugreek leaves can replace kasuri methi; omit turmeric if preferred.

Recipe: Simple Egg Pulao Quick

Ingredients: basmati rice, hard-boiled eggs, onions, biryani masala powder, ginger-garlic paste, oil, water, salt

Instructions: Wash and soak rice. Hard-boil eggs, peel them, and fry them in oil with a pinch of turmeric until skin blisters. In a pot, heat oil and fry sliced onions and ginger-garlic paste until brown. Stir in biryani masala powder and salt. Add the soaked rice and water, bringing to a boil. Drop the fried whole eggs gently into the liquid, cover tightly with a lid, turn the heat to low, and let it steam for 12 minutes until cooked.

Substitutions: Cut eggs in half and place them on top of the cooked rice right before steaming to preserve structural look.

Recipe: Garlic Fried Rice Express

Ingredients: pre-cooked rice, garlic, soy sauce, oil, green onions, salt, pepper

Instructions: Finely mince a large amount of fresh garlic cloves. Heat a generous pool of oil in a wide wok over high heat. Add the minced garlic and fry rapidly for 1 minute until fragrant and lightly golden brown but not burnt. Throw in cold leftover rice, cranking the heat up to maximum. Toss continuously for 3 minutes, drizzling with a tablespoon of soy sauce, salt, and black pepper. Stir in chopped green onion tops and remove from heat.

Substitutions: Add a scrambled egg or diced vegetables along with the garlic to make it a wholesome meal.

Recipe: Soft Bhatura Express

Ingredients: all-purpose flour, yogurt, baking powder, sugar, oil, water, salt

Instructions: Whisk all-purpose flour (maida) with a teaspoon of baking powder, a pinch of sugar, salt, and a generous half-cup of yogurt. Knead into a smooth, elastic dough, adding a little water if required. Drizzle oil over the dough, cover, and let it rest in a warm place for at least 30 minutes. Divide into balls, roll out into thick oval shapes, and deep-fry immediately in smoking-hot oil, pouring oil over the top until it puffs up massively.

Substitutions: Add a tablespoon of semolina (sooji) to the dough to help the bhatras stay puffed up longer.

Recipe: Comforting Tomato Saar

Ingredients: tomatoes, grated coconut, cumin seeds, green chilies, mustard seeds, curry leaves, ghee, salt

Instructions: Boil tomatoes in water until skins burst, then peel and puree them. Blend fresh grated coconut, cumin seeds, and green chilies into a smooth paste with a little water. In a pot, combine the tomato puree, coconut paste, and salt, bringing to a gentle simmer for 5 minutes. In a small pan, heat ghee, splutter mustard seeds, and fry curry leaves, pouring this hot tempering directly into the tomato soup before turning off the heat.

Substitutions: Skip the coconut paste for a light, clear tomato broth; use oil instead of ghee for a vegan option.

Recipe: Easy Tomato Thokku

Ingredients: tomatoes, mustard seeds, turmeric powder, red chili powder, asafoetida, oil, salt

Instructions: Finely chop ripe red tomatoes. Heat a generous amount of oil in a pan, splutter mustard seeds, and add a pinch of asafoetida (hing). Add the chopped tomatoes, turmeric powder, red chili powder, and salt. Cook uncovered on medium heat, stirring frequently, as the tomatoes completely break down, lose their moisture, and thicken into a dark red, shiny, jam-like relish where oil begins to pool at the edges. Store in a glass jar.

Substitutions: Add a tiny piece of jaggery at the end to balance the intense acidity; adjust chili for personal preference.

Recipe: Homestyle Chicken Curry

Ingredients: chicken, onions, tomatoes, ginger-garlic paste, turmeric, red chili powder, coriander powder, garam masala, oil, salt, water

Instructions: Marinate chicken pieces with turmeric, chili powder, and salt for 15 minutes. Heat oil in a heavy-bottomed pot and fry finely chopped onions until deep golden brown. Stir in ginger-garlic paste and chopped tomatoes, cooking until the mixture softens and oil begins to separate from the sides. Add the marinated chicken, coriander powder, and garam masala, searing the meat on high heat for 5 minutes. Pour in a cup of water, cover with a lid, and simmer on medium-low heat for 20 to 25 minutes until the chicken is tender.

Substitutions: Use chicken thighs or drumsticks for the juiciest results; yogurt can replace tomatoes for acidity.

Recipe: Simple Egg Curry

Ingredients: eggs, onions, tomatoes, ginger-garlic paste, turmeric, red chili powder, cumin seeds, oil, salt, water

Instructions: Hard-boil the eggs, peel them, and score them lightly with a knife. Sauté the eggs in a pan with a pinch of turmeric and oil until a blistering golden skin forms, then remove. In the same pan, crackle cumin seeds and fry chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste until brown. Add chopped tomatoes, chili powder, and salt, cooking into a smooth paste. Pour in a half-cup of water to form a gravy, bring to a boil, then slide in the fried eggs, simmering for 5 minutes until the sauce coats them.

Substitutions: Tomato puree can replace fresh chopped tomatoes; add boiled potato wedges to bulk up the dish.

Recipe: Bengali Fish Curry (Machher Jhol)

Ingredients: fish fillets, potatoes, tomatoes, ginger paste, turmeric powder, red chili powder, panch phoron, mustard oil, salt, water

Instructions: Marinate fish fillets with turmeric and salt, then fry in smoking-hot mustard oil until golden brown on both sides; remove and set aside. In the same oil, add panch phoron (five-spice mix) and sauté wedged potatoes and chopped tomatoes. Stir in ginger paste, turmeric, chili powder, and salt. Pour in water and bring the broth to a boil. Slide the fried fish fillets into the bubbling gravy, lower the heat, and cook uncovered for 8 to 10 minutes until the potatoes are tender.

Substitutions: Any firm white fish or rohu can be used; regular neutral cooking oil can replace mustard oil.

Recipe: Quick Chicken Stir-Fry (Pepper Chicken)

Ingredients: chicken, onions, black pepper powder, garlic, curry leaves, turmeric powder, oil, salt

Instructions: Cut chicken into small, bite-sized pieces and toss with turmeric and salt. Heat oil in a wide skillet, add curry leaves and a large amount of finely chopped garlic, sautéing until fragrant. Add chopped onions and cook until soft. Throw in the chicken pieces and stir-fry on high heat for 5 minutes to sear the meat. Reduce heat to medium, cover, and let the chicken cook in its own juices for 10 minutes. Remove lid, add a generous tablespoon of coarsely crushed black pepper, and stir-fry until completely dry.

Substitutions: Chicken breast cubes cook fastest; adjust black pepper depending on your spice tolerance.

Recipe: Goan Prawn Balchao Express

Ingredients: prawns, onions, tomato paste, garlic, ginger, vinegar, red chili powder, cumin powder, sugar, oil, salt

Instructions: Clean and devein the prawns, then sprinkle with salt. In a small bowl, mix red chili powder, cumin powder, and white vinegar into a thick, tangy paste. Heat oil in a pan and sauté finely chopped onions and

minced ginger-garlic until the onions turn soft and brownish. Add tomato paste and the vinegar-spice mixture, cooking for 3 minutes. Toss in the prawns and a pinch of sugar, stir-frying over medium heat for 4 to 5 minutes until the prawns turn opaque and cook through. Substitutions: Apple cider vinegar or tamarind paste can replace white vinegar; adjust sugar to balance heat.

Recipe: Easy Mughlai Egg Korma

Ingredients: eggs, onions, cashew nut paste, ginger-garlic paste, yogurt, garam masala, turmeric, ghee, salt, water

Instructions: Hard-boil and peel the eggs. Fry sliced onions until dark brown, then blend into a paste with yogurt and cashew nuts. Heat ghee in a pot, sauté ginger-garlic paste, then stir in the onion-cashew paste, turmeric, and salt on low heat. Pour in a half-cup of water and bring to a simmer. Cut the hard-boiled eggs in half and gently place them into the bubbling white-gravy sauce, sprinkling garam masala over the top. Simmer covered for 5 minutes.

Substitutions: Almond paste can replace cashew paste; regular oil can replace ghee.

Recipe: Simple Mutton Curry Express

Ingredients: mutton, onions, tomatoes, ginger-garlic paste, meat masala powder, turmeric, oil, salt, water

Instructions: Marinate the mutton pieces with yogurt, turmeric, and salt for at least 30 minutes. Heat oil in a pressure cooker and fry plenty of chopped onions until deep golden brown. Add ginger-garlic paste and chopped tomatoes, cooking until soft. Add the marinated mutton and meat masala powder, browning the meat thoroughly on high heat for 7 to 8 minutes. Pour in 1.5 cups of water, secure the pressure cooker lid, and cook for 5 to 6 whistles on medium heat until the meat is completely tender.

Substitutions: Cooking in an open heavy pot takes about 1.5 hours; increase marination time to help tenderize meat.

Recipe: Homestyle Chicken Sukka

Ingredients: chicken, grated coconut, dry red chilies, coriander seeds, cumin seeds, onions, garlic, oil, salt

Instructions: Dry roast coriander seeds, cumin seeds, and dry red chilies, then grind with fresh grated coconut and garlic into a thick, coarse spice paste. Heat oil in a pan and fry chopped onions until golden. Add chicken pieces and salt, stir-frying on high heat for 5 minutes. Reduce heat, cover, and let the chicken cook completely in its own moisture. Once the chicken is cooked, add the coconut-spice paste and roast uncovered on medium-high heat until the sauce dries up and coats the chicken pieces heavily.

Substitutions: Desiccated coconut powder mixed with a little water can replace fresh grated coconut.

Recipe: Quick Tawa Fish Fry

Ingredients: fish fillets, ginger-garlic paste, red chili powder, turmeric, lemon juice, rice flour, oil, salt

Instructions: Mix ginger-garlic paste, red chili powder, turmeric powder, salt, and fresh lemon juice into a smooth, thick marinade paste. Coat the fish fillets thoroughly with this spice paste and let them sit for 15 minutes. Lightly dredge both sides of the marinated fish in a shallow plate of rice flour to create a thin coating. Heat a small pool of oil on a flat tawa or skillet and shallow-fry the fish fillets for 4 minutes per side until the exterior skin turns exceptionally crispy.

Substitutions: Semolina (rava) can replace rice flour for an even crunchier outer texture.

Recipe: Spicy Egg Bhurji (Scrambled Eggs)

Ingredients: eggs, onions, tomatoes, green chilies, red chili powder, turmeric powder, oil, salt, cilantro

Instructions: Finely chop onions, tomatoes, and green chilies. Heat oil in a wide frying pan and sauté the onions and green chilies until the onions turn translucent. Add the chopped tomatoes, turmeric powder, red chili powder, and salt, cooking down until the tomatoes soften completely. Crack the eggs directly into the pan over the cooked vegetable base. Stir vigorously with a spatula to scramble the eggs, cooking for 3 to 4 minutes until soft curds form and dry out slightly. Garnish with fresh cilantro.

Substitutions: Butter can be used instead of oil; add a pinch of pav bhaji masala for a street-style flavor twist.

Recipe: Simple Prawn Masala

Ingredients: prawns, onions, tomatoes, ginger-garlic paste, turmeric, coriander powder, oil, salt, cilantro

Instructions: Clean and wash prawns. Heat oil in a pan, fry chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste until brown, then add chopped tomatoes, turmeric, coriander powder, and salt. Cook until the tomatoes break down into a thick masala base. Toss in the prawns and mix well to coat with the spices; do not add water, as prawns release their own liquid. Cover and cook on medium-low heat for exactly 5 minutes until the prawns curl up and turn opaque. Garnish with chopped cilantro leaves.

Substitutions: Overcooking prawns makes them rubbery, so stick strictly to 5 minutes; add coconut milk for gravy.

Recipe: Malabar Chicken Curry Quick

Ingredients: chicken, coconut milk, onions, tomatoes, ginger, garlic, curry leaves, mustard seeds, turmeric, oil, salt

Instructions: Heat oil in a pot, splutter mustard seeds, and fry curry leaves, chopped onions, minced ginger, and garlic until golden. Add chopped tomatoes, turmeric powder, and salt, cooking until soft. Toss in chicken pieces and sear for 5 minutes. Pour in a half-cup of water, cover, and cook on medium heat for 15 minutes. Turn the heat down to low and pour in thick coconut milk, stirring gently. Simmer for 3 minutes without boiling, so the coconut milk does not split.

Substitutions: Adjust the consistency by using thin coconut milk first, then finishing with thick cream.

Recipe: Easy Chicken Kheema Masala

Ingredients: minced chicken, onions, tomatoes, ginger-garlic paste, garam masala, turmeric, red chili powder, oil, salt, green peas

Instructions: Heat oil in a pan and sauté finely chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste until rich brown. Add chopped tomatoes, turmeric, chili powder, and salt, mashing into a smooth sauce. Add the minced chicken (kheema) and green peas, stirring vigorously to break up any meat clumps. Sauté the mince for 5 minutes until it changes color. Lower the heat, cover, and let it cook in its own juices for 12 minutes until tender. Sprinkle garam masala and serve dry.

Substitutions: Minced mutton can be used but requires a longer simmering time or pressure cooking.

Recipe: Simple Egg Roast (Kerala Style)

Ingredients: eggs, onions, tomatoes, curry leaves, fennel powder, red chili powder, turmeric, oil, salt

Instructions: Hard-boil and peel the eggs, slicing them in half lengthwise. Slice onions very thinly. Heat oil in a pan, fry curry leaves and the sliced onions slowly on medium-low heat for 10 minutes until

caramelized and brown. Add chopped tomatoes, turmeric powder, red chili powder, fennel powder, and salt, cooking until mushy. Push the thick onion paste to the sides, place the egg halves cut-side down in the center, sear for 2 minutes, flip gently, and coat with the onion mixture. Substitutions: Fennel powder is key for the flavor profile, but garam masala can stand in if necessary.

Recipe: Homestyle Chicken Fry

Ingredients: chicken, chili powder, turmeric, coriander powder, ginger-garlic paste, lemon juice, cornstarch, oil, salt

Instructions: Make deep gashes in chicken pieces and marinate with chili powder, turmeric, coriander powder, ginger-garlic paste, salt, and a squeeze of lemon juice for 30 minutes. Toss the marinated chicken with a tablespoon of cornstarch to bind the juices. Heat oil in a frying pan and place the chicken pieces inside, frying covered on medium heat for 7 minutes per side. Remove the lid and flash-fry on high heat for 2 minutes until the skin turns crispy and dark red.

Substitutions: Deep-fry instead of shallow-frying for an even crisper skin; use boneless cubes for quick chicken bites.

Recipe: Classic Aloo Gobi

Ingredients: potatoes, cauliflower, onions, tomatoes, ginger-garlic paste, turmeric, coriander powder, cumin seeds, oil, salt, cilantro

Instructions: Cut cauliflower into florets and potatoes into wedges. Heat oil, crackle cumin seeds, and sauté chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste until golden. Add chopped tomatoes, turmeric, coriander powder, and salt, cooking down until mushy. Toss in the potatoes and cauliflower florets, coating them thoroughly in the spice mix. Turn heat to low, cover the pan with a tight lid, and let it steam in its own moisture for 15 to 20 minutes, stirring occasionally, until vegetables are tender. Garnish with fresh cilantro.

Substitutions: Pan-fry potatoes and cauliflower separately before adding to the masala base to shorten steaming time.

Recipe: Simple Bhindi Masala

Ingredients: okra, onions, tomatoes, turmeric powder, red chili powder, amchur, cumin seeds, oil, salt

Instructions: Wash and wipe the okra (bhindi) completely dry with a towel to prevent sliminess, then chop into half-inch pieces. Heat oil in a wide pan, add cumin seeds, and sauté sliced onions until soft. Add the chopped bhindi and cook uncovered on medium heat for 8 to 10 minutes, stirring gently until they shrink and lose their stickiness. Stir in chopped tomatoes, turmeric powder, chili powder, amchur (dry mango powder), and salt. Cook for another 5 minutes until everything is tender.

Substitutions: Lemon juice can replace amchur powder for acidity; omit tomatoes if you prefer a drier, crisper finish.

Recipe: Punjabi Chole Masala

Ingredients: chickpeas, onions, tomatoes, ginger-garlic paste, chole masala powder, turmeric, tea bag, oil, cumin seeds, salt, cilantro

Instructions: Soak raw chickpeas overnight, then pressure cook with salt, water, and a tea bag until tender and dark; discard the tea bag. Heat oil in a deep pot, crackle cumin seeds, and fry finely chopped onions until dark brown. Add ginger-garlic paste and chopped tomatoes, cooking until oil separates. Stir in turmeric and a generous amount of chole masala powder. Pour in the boiled chickpeas along with their cooking water, mashing a few chickpeas with a spoon to thicken the gravy. Simmer for 15 minutes.

Substitutions: Canned chickpeas save soaking time; use amchur and garam masala if readymade chole powder is unavailable.

Recipe: Classic Dal Tadka

Ingredients: yellow pigeon peas, onions, tomatoes, green chilies, ginger, garlic, mustard seeds, cumin seeds, turmeric powder, ghee, salt, cilantro

Instructions: Pressure cook the yellow lentils (toor dal) with water, turmeric, and salt until smooth and mushy. In a separate pan, heat ghee for the tempering (tadka). Splutter mustard seeds and cumin seeds, then sauté finely chopped onions, minced ginger, green chilies, and a large amount of chopped garlic until golden brown. Pour this aromatic tempering directly over the hot, whisked boiled dal. Simmer for 2 minutes and garnish heavily with fresh cilantro leaves.

Substitutions: Regular cooking oil can replace ghee for a vegan variant; red lentils (masoor dal) can replace pigeon peas.

Recipe: Jeera Aloo

Ingredients: potatoes, cumin seeds, turmeric powder, red chili powder, amchur, oil, salt, cilantro

Instructions: Boil, peel, and dice the potatoes into cubes, letting them cool down completely so they hold their shape. Heat oil in a wide skillet over medium heat. Add a generous tablespoon of whole cumin seeds (jeera)

and let them sizzle and turn brown without burning. Drop in the potato cubes, then add turmeric powder, red chili powder, amchur, and salt. Stir-fry gently on medium-high heat for 5 to 7 minutes until the potatoes develop a crispy golden crust coated in cumin seeds. Garnish with cilantro.

Substitutions: Ghee gives a richer aroma than cooking oil; chat masala can replace amchur powder.

Recipe: Simple Lauki Ki Sabzi

Ingredients: bottle gourd, tomatoes, cumin seeds, turmeric powder, coriander powder, oil, salt, cilantro

Instructions: Peel the bottle gourd (lauki) and chop it into small, even cubes. Heat oil in a pressure cooker or deep pot, crackle cumin seeds, and add chopped tomatoes, cooking until soft. Stir in turmeric powder, coriander powder, and salt. Add the chopped lauki cubes and toss well with the spices. Close the cooker and cook for 2 whistles on medium heat without adding any external water, as bottle gourd releases plenty of its own liquid. Open and garnish with fresh cilantro.

Substitutions: Can cook in an open pot covered with a lid, though it takes longer; add a pinch of chili powder for spice.

Recipe: Baingan Bharta

Ingredients: eggplants, onions, tomatoes, garlic, green chilies, red chili powder, oil, salt, cilantro

Instructions: Poke a few holes in a large purple eggplant (baingan), brush it lightly with oil, and roast it directly over an open gas flame, turning occasionally, until the skin turns completely charred and black and the flesh collapses. Let it cool, peel off the burnt skin, and mash the smoky flesh thoroughly. Heat oil in a pan, fry chopped onions, minced garlic, and green chilies until golden. Add chopped tomatoes and chili powder, cooking until soft, then stir in the mashed eggplant and salt, sautéing for 5 minutes.

Substitutions: Roast the eggplant in an oven at 200°C if an open gas flame is unavailable; add green peas for texture.

Recipe: Homestyle Paneer Bhurji

Ingredients: paneer, onions, tomatoes, green chilies, ginger, turmeric powder, garam masala, butter, salt, cilantro

Instructions: Crumble fresh paneer with your fingers and set aside. Melt butter or heat oil in a pan, and sauté finely chopped onions, minced ginger, and chopped green chilies until the onions turn translucent. Add chopped tomatoes, turmeric powder, and salt, cooking until the tomatoes soften. Turn the heat down to low, add the crumbled paneer, and toss gently for 2 to 3 minutes; do not overcook, or the paneer will turn rubbery. Sprinkle garam masala and fresh cilantro before turning off heat.

Substitutions: Tofu can completely replace paneer for a vegan version; add finely chopped bell peppers for a crunch.

Recipe: Simple Cabbage Fry (Patta Gobi)

Ingredients: cabbage, green peas, potatoes, mustard seeds, turmeric powder, green chilies, oil, salt

Instructions: Shred the cabbage thinly, and cut the potatoes into small, thin cubes. Heat oil in a pan, splutter mustard seeds, and add chopped green chilies. Add the potato cubes and stir-fry for 3 minutes until lightly browned. Toss in the shredded cabbage and green peas, followed by turmeric powder and salt. Mix thoroughly, lower the heat, and cover the pan with a lid. Let it cook in its own steam for 10 to 12 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the potatoes are tender and cabbage is soft.

Substitutions: Omit potatoes if you want a pure cabbage side dish; use cumin seeds if mustard seeds aren't preferred.

Recipe: Quick Kadai Mushroom

Ingredients: mushrooms, bell peppers, onions, tomatoes, ginger-garlic paste, coriander powder, garam masala, oil, salt

Instructions: Slice the button mushrooms, and cut the bell peppers and onions into large square petals. Heat oil in a pan and sauté the onion and bell pepper petals on high heat for 2 minutes until tender-crisp; remove and set aside. In the same pan, sauté chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste, add chopped tomatoes, coriander powder, garam masala, and salt, cooking until mushy. Add the sliced mushrooms and cook for 5 minutes as they release water. Toss back the bell peppers and onions, simmering until the sauce reduces.

Substitutions: Paneer can be added alongside mushrooms; use fresh black pepper for flavor punch.

Recipe: Basic Matar Paneer

Ingredients: paneer, green peas, onions, tomatoes, ginger-garlic paste, turmeric, coriander powder, garam masala, oil, salt

Instructions: Cube the paneer and optionally shallow-fry until golden. Puree the onions and tomatoes separately. Heat oil in a pot, fry the onion puree and ginger-garlic paste until golden brown, then add the tomato puree, turmeric, coriander powder, and salt, cooking until oil droplets appear on the surface. Stir in the green peas and a cup of water, bringing to a boil. Add the paneer cubes, sprinkle garam masala, cover, and let it simmer on low heat for 5 to 7 minutes until the gravy thickens nicely.

Substitutions: Use frozen or fresh green peas; heavy cream can be swirled in at the end for a richer restaurant-style feel.

Recipe: Classic Mixed Vegetable Sabzi

Ingredients: carrots, French beans, green peas, potatoes, onions, tomatoes, ginger-garlic paste, garam masala, turmeric, oil, salt

Instructions: Chop all vegetables (carrots, beans, potatoes) into uniform small pieces. Heat oil in a pan, sauté chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste, then add chopped tomatoes, turmeric, and salt, cooking until soft. Add the potatoes and carrots first with a splash of water, cover, and cook for 5 minutes. Toss in the beans and green peas, mix well, and cover again, cooking on low heat for 10 minutes until all vegetables are fork-tender. Stir in garam masala before serving.

Substitutions: Throw in cauliflower florets or paneer cubes to enrich the vegetable medley.

Recipe: Simple Ghee Dal Fry

Ingredients: yellow pigeon peas, onions, tomatoes, garlic, red chili powder, turmeric, ghee, cumin seeds, salt

Instructions: Boil yellow pigeon peas (toor dal) with water, salt, and turmeric until fully mashed. Heat a generous pool of ghee in a pan, crackle cumin seeds, and fry finely chopped onions and a large amount of minced garlic until deep golden brown. Stir in chopped tomatoes and red chili powder, mashing the tomatoes until they meld into the hot ghee. Pour the boiled dal into this pan, stir thoroughly, and bring to a rolling boil for 3 minutes until the flavors fuse.

Substitutions: Use butter instead of ghee; split green gram (moong dal) can replace pigeon peas.

Recipe: Quick Aloo Matar

Ingredients: potatoes, green peas, onions, tomatoes, ginger-garlic paste, turmeric, red chili powder, oil, salt, water

Instructions: Peel and cube the potatoes. Heat oil in a pressure cooker or deep pan, sauté chopped onions and ginger-garlic paste until soft, then stir in chopped tomatoes, turmeric, chili powder, and salt, cooking until mushy. Add the potato cubes and green peas, stirring for 2 minutes to coat with spices. Pour in a cup of water, close the pressure cooker lid, and cook for 2 whistles on medium heat. If cooking in an open pot, cover and simmer for 15 minutes until potatoes are soft.

Substitutions: Adjust water quantity depending on whether you want a dry side dish or a pourable gravy.

Recipe: Simple Sukhi Beans

Ingredients: French beans, grated coconut, mustard seeds, green chilies, turmeric, oil, salt

Instructions: Wash and chop the French beans into tiny, even rounds. Heat oil in a pan, splutter mustard seeds, and add chopped green chilies. Add the chopped beans, turmeric powder, and salt, tossing well. Pour in two tablespoons of water, cover the pan tightly with a lid, and let it cook on low heat for 8 minutes until the beans are tender but still retain their bright green color. Remove the lid, cook off any remaining moisture, and stir in fresh grated coconut.

Substitutions: Omit fresh coconut if unavailable; swap French beans with long yard beans or cluster beans.

Recipe: Easy Dum Aloo

Ingredients: baby potatoes, onions, tomatoes, ginger-garlic paste, yogurt, garam masala, Kashmiri chili powder, turmeric, oil, salt

Instructions: Boil baby potatoes until just cooked, peel them, and prick them all over with a toothpick; shallow-fry in oil until golden and crispy. Make a paste of fried onions and tomatoes. Heat oil, sauté ginger-garlic paste and the onion-tomato paste, then add turmeric, Kashmiri chili powder, and salt. Whisk yogurt and add it on low heat, stirring continuously to prevent curdling. Add the fried baby potatoes and a half-cup of water. Cover tightly and simmer on very low heat for 10 minutes.

Substitutions: Regular large potatoes cut into big chunks can replace baby potatoes if needed.

Recipe: Classic Poha

Ingredients: flattened rice, onions, potatoes, green chilies, mustard seeds, turmeric powder, peanuts, oil, salt, lemon juice, cilantro

Instructions: Rinse the flattened rice (poha) in a strainer until soft, then set aside. Heat oil in a pan, fry the peanuts until crunchy, and remove them. In the same oil, splutter mustard seeds, then sauté finely chopped onions, diced potatoes, and green chilies until the potatoes are cooked. Stir in turmeric powder and salt. Add the rinsed poha and fried peanuts, mixing gently on low heat for 3 minutes. Squeeze fresh lemon juice and garnish with chopped cilantro before serving.

Substitutions: Skip potatoes for a lighter version; use roasted chana dal if peanuts are unavailable.

Recipe: Mumbai Batata Vada

Ingredients: potatoes, gram flour, green chilies, garlic, ginger, mustard seeds, turmeric powder, oil, salt, baking pinch

Instructions: Boil, peel, and mash the potatoes. Make a coarse paste of green chilies, garlic, and ginger. Heat a teaspoon of oil, splutter mustard seeds, add the spice paste, turmeric, and salt, then mix thoroughly into the mashed potatoes. Shape into round balls. Create a smooth, thick batter using gram flour, water, a pinch of salt, and a pinch of baking soda. Dip the potato balls into the batter to coat evenly, then deep-fry in hot oil until golden brown and crispy.

Substitutions: Use lemon juice in the potato mix if you want a tangier profile; adjust chili quantities to taste.

Recipe: Instant Rava Idli

Ingredients: semolina, yogurt, eno fruit salt, mustard seeds, cashew nuts, ginger, green chilies, oil, salt, water

Instructions: Heat a tablespoon of oil, fry cashew nuts until golden, then add mustard seeds, minced ginger, and chopped green chilies. Add semolina (rava) to the pan and roast on low heat for 5 minutes until fragrant but not browned; let it cool. Mix the roasted rava with plain yogurt, water, and salt to form a thick batter, letting it rest for 15 minutes. Right before steaming, stir in eno fruit salt. Pour into greased idli molds and steam for 10 to 12 minutes.

Substitutions: Use baking soda if eno fruit salt is missing; add grated carrots to the batter for color.

Recipe: Classic Upma

Ingredients: semolina, onions, green chilies, ginger, mustard seeds, urad dal, curry leaves, oil, water, salt, ghee

Instructions: Dry roast the semolina (rava) in a pan on medium heat for 4 to 5 minutes until lightly fragrant, then set aside. Heat oil or ghee in a pan, add mustard seeds, urad dal, curry leaves, chopped green chilies, and minced ginger, sautéing until the dal turns golden. Add chopped onions and cook until translucent. Pour in 3 cups of water and add salt, bringing it to a rolling boil. Slowly pour in the roasted rava while stirring continuously to prevent lumps. Cover and simmer on low heat for 3 minutes until dry and fluffy.

Substitutions: Any neutral cooking oil can replace ghee; add frozen green peas or diced carrots along with onions.

Recipe: Sabudana Khichdi

Ingredients: tapioca pearls, potatoes, peanuts, green chilies, cumin seeds, oil, salt, sugar, lemon juice, cilantro

Instructions: Rinse sabudana thoroughly and soak in just enough water to cover them for 4 to 6 hours until puffy and dry. Dry roast the peanuts, peel them, and crush into a coarse powder. Mix the peanut powder, salt, and a pinch of sugar into the soaked sabudana. Heat oil in a pan, crackle

cumin seeds, and sauté diced parboiled potatoes and chopped green chilies until the potatoes are golden. Add the sabudana mixture and cook on low heat, stirring continuously, until the pearls turn translucent. Squeeze lemon juice and garnish with cilantro.

Substitutions: Use rock salt (sendha namak) to make it suitable for fasting rituals; ghee can replace cooking oil.

Recipe: Simple Sooji Ka Halwa

Ingredients: semolina, sugar, ghee, water, cardamom powder, cashew nuts

Instructions: Heat ghee in a deep pan, add cashew nuts, fry until golden brown, and set aside. In the same ghee, add semolina (rava) and roast on low-medium heat for 7 to 8 minutes, stirring constantly until it turns a deep golden-pink color and releases an aromatic scent. Meanwhile, boil water and sugar together in a separate pot until the sugar dissolves. Slowly pour the hot sugar water into the roasted rava while whisking rapidly to avoid lumps. Simmer until the water is fully absorbed and the halwa leaves the sides of the pan. Stir in cardamom powder and fried cashews.

Substitutions: Milk can replace water for a richer texture; use jaggery powder instead of white sugar.

Recipe: Punjabi Bread Pakora

Ingredients: bread, potatoes, gram flour, green chilies, coriander powder, amchur, turmeric, oil, salt, water

Instructions: Boil and mash the potatoes, then mix with chopped green chilies, coriander powder, dry mango powder (amchur), and salt to create a flavorful stuffing. Spread this potato mix evenly between two slices of bread, press them firmly together, and cut diagonally into triangles. Whisk gram flour (besan) with turmeric, a pinch of chili powder, salt, and water to make a smooth, semi-thick dipping batter. Heat deep-frying oil in a kadhai. Dip the stuffed bread triangles into the besan batter to coat completely and immediately slide into hot oil, frying until crispy and golden brown.

Substitutions: Place a slice of paneer inside the bread along with potatoes; swap amchur with chat masala.

Recipe: Basic Methi Thepla

Ingredients: whole wheat flour, fresh fenugreek leaves, yogurt, turmeric, chili powder, carom seeds, oil, salt, water

Instructions: Wash and finely chop the fresh fenugreek (methi) leaves. In a large mixing bowl, combine whole wheat flour, chopped methi leaves, turmeric powder, red chili powder, carom seeds (ajwain), a tablespoon of oil, yogurt, and salt. Knead into a soft, smooth dough, adding a little water only if needed, as the yogurt and leaves provide moisture. Divide into small balls and roll out into very thin flatbreads. Cook on a hot tawa or griddle, applying a teaspoon of oil on both sides, pressing down with a spatula until golden spots appear.

Substitutions: Dried fenugreek leaves (kasuri methi) can be used if fresh leaves are unavailable; omit yogurt for a longer shelf life.

Recipe: Quick Besan Chilla

Ingredients: gram flour, onions, tomatoes, green chilies, carom seeds, turmeric powder, cilantro, oil, salt, water

Instructions: In a large bowl, whisk together gram flour (besan), finely chopped onions, chopped tomatoes, minced green chilies, carom seeds (ajwain), turmeric powder, chopped cilantro, and salt. Gradually add water and whisk thoroughly to form a smooth, pourable batter with a pouring consistency similar to pancake batter. Heat a non-stick tawa and grease it lightly with oil. Pour a ladleful of batter in the center and spread it in a circular motion to form a thin crepe. Drizzle oil around

the edges, cook for 2 minutes until the bottom turns golden, flip, and cook the other side.

Substitutions: Add grated paneer or cheese over the chilla while cooking; mix a tablespoon of rice flour for an extra crispy edge.

Recipe: Kanda Bhajji (Onion Fritters)

Ingredients: onions, gram flour, green chilies, turmeric powder, carom seeds, cilantro, oil, salt

Instructions: Slice the onions very thinly. Place the sliced onions in a bowl, sprinkle salt over them, and mix with your hands, squeezing gently. Let it sit for 10 minutes; the salt will draw out water from the onions. Add chopped green chilies, turmeric powder, carom seeds (ajwain), and chopped cilantro. Gradually sprinkle gram flour (besan) over the onions, mixing thoroughly with your fingers until a thick, sticky batter coats the slices without adding any external water. Heat oil for deep frying, drop small portions of the onion mix, and fry until ultra-crispy and dark golden.

Substitutions: Add a pinch of red chili powder for extra heat; a tablespoon of rice flour makes them stay crispy longer.

Recipe: Classic Masala Omelet

Ingredients: eggs, onions, tomatoes, green chilies, turmeric powder, cilantro, butter, salt, pepper

Instructions: Finely chop the onions, tomatoes, green chilies, and cilantro. Crack the eggs into a bowl, add a pinch of turmeric powder, salt, and black pepper, and whisk vigorously until frothy. Stir the chopped vegetables directly into the whisked egg mixture. Melt butter in a non-stick frying pan over medium heat, swirling to coat the surface. Pour in the egg mix, spreading the vegetables evenly. Cook for 2 minutes until the base sets, flip carefully, and cook the other side for another minute until fluffy.

Substitutions: Cooking oil can replace butter; add a handful of shredded cheddar cheese before folding.

Recipe: Aloo Tuk

Ingredients: potatoes, oil, salt, red chili powder, coriander powder, amchur, cumin powder

Instructions: Peel the potatoes and cut them into large, thick round discs or chunks. Heat oil in a deep pan and fry the potato pieces on medium heat until they are cooked through but still pale; remove them from the oil. While warm, gently press each potato piece between your palms or under a flat glass to flatten it slightly without breaking it apart. Re-heat the oil to high and flash-fry the flattened potatoes until they turn deep golden brown and exceptionally crispy. Toss immediately in a bowl with salt, chili powder, coriander powder, amchur, and cumin powder.

Substitutions: Sweet potatoes can be treated with the same deep-frying technique; use chat masala for convenience.

Recipe: Gujarati Khaman Dhokla

Ingredients: gram flour, semolina, sugar, lemon juice, turmeric, eno fruit salt, mustard seeds, green chilies, oil, curry leaves, water

Instructions: Whisk gram flour (besan), a tablespoon of semolina, sugar, lemon juice, a pinch of turmeric, salt, oil, and water into a smooth batter; rest for 10 minutes. Stir in eno fruit salt rapidly until the batter double in volume, then immediately pour into a greased pan and steam for 15 minutes. Cut into squares. For the tempering, heat oil, crackle mustard seeds, add curry leaves and sliced green chilies, pour in a half-cup of water with a little sugar, and bring to a boil. Pour this warm sweet-savory water uniformly over the steamed dhokla squares.

Substitutions: Use citric acid instead of fresh lemon juice; omit semolina if you want a purely gluten-free texture.

Recipe: Simple Vegetable Cutlet

Ingredients: potatoes, carrots, green peas, breadcrumbs, ginger-garlic paste, garam masala, chili powder, cornstarch, oil, salt

Instructions: Boil, peel, and mash the potatoes. Steam finely diced carrots and green peas, combining them thoroughly with the mashed potatoes. Add ginger-garlic paste, garam masala, red chili powder, and salt, mixing well to form a tight dough. Shape into flat round or oval patties. Make a thin slurry with cornstarch and water. Dip each patty into the cornstarch slurry, roll it in breadcrumbs until fully coated, and shallow-fry in a pan with hot oil until both sides are exceptionally crispy and brown.

Substitutions: Use powdered oats instead of breadcrumbs for coating; add crumbled paneer to the vegetable mix.

Recipe: Sugary Shakarpara

Ingredients: all-purpose flour, ghee, sugar, water, oil

Instructions: Melt sugar in warm water and let it cool. In a wide bowl, rub ghee into all-purpose flour (maida) with your fingertips until it resembles coarse breadcrumbs. Pour in the sugar water gradually, kneading into a firm, stiff dough. Roll the dough out into a thick flat sheet. Using a knife, slice the sheet into small diamond or square shapes. Heat oil in a pan over medium-low heat and deep-fry the diamonds slowly, turning occasionally, until they turn an even light golden brown and crisp up as they cool down.

Substitutions: Whole wheat flour can replace maida for a denser version; bake them at 180°C for an oil-free bake.

Recipe: Namakpara (Savory Diamonds)

Ingredients: all-purpose flour, carom seeds, ghee, oil, salt, water

Instructions: Mix all-purpose flour (maida), carom seeds (ajwain), a generous spoonful of ghee, and salt in a bowl, rubbing well until the flour holds its shape when pressed in your palm. Add cold water bit by bit, kneading into a very stiff, hard dough; rest covered for 20 minutes. Roll out a portion into a thin circle and slice into narrow diamond patterns. Deep-fry the pieces in medium-hot oil, stirring gently, until crisp and golden brown.

Substitutions: Black cumin seeds (kalonji) can replace carom seeds; whole wheat flour can be mixed half-and-half.

Recipe: Simple Buttered Noodles

Ingredients: pasta, butter, salt

Instructions: Cook any pasta shape in a large pot of boiling water that has been generously salted. Once the pasta is soft and tender, drain it thoroughly through a colander, leaving just a tiny drop of moisture. Return the hot pasta back into the warm empty pot, throw in a large block of butter and a pinch of salt, and toss rapidly until the butter melts completely and coats the strands.

Substitutions: Olive oil or margarine can replace butter. Black pepper adds a nice touch.

Recipe: Quick Tomato Toasties

Ingredients: bread, tomato sauce, cheese

Instructions: Place your slices of bread flat on a baking sheet or inside a dry frying pan. Toast one side, flip over, and spread a thin layer of regular tomato sauce or ketchup over the toasted surface. Top heavily with shredded or sliced cheese. Cover the pan with a lid or place under an oven broiler for 3 minutes until the cheese is completely melted, bubbly, and golden.

Substitutions: Any block cheese or processed slice can be used.

Recipe: Crispy Tortilla Chips

Ingredients: tortillas, oil, salt

Instructions: Take a stack of corn or flour tortillas and use a knife to slice them into small triangular wedges. Heat a thin layer of oil in a wide skillet over medium-high heat. Drop the tortilla triangles into the hot oil in batches to avoid crowding. Fry for 1 to 2 minutes per side until they turn completely stiff, crispy, and golden brown. Drain on paper towels and dust with salt immediately.

Substitutions: Can be baked at 200°C for 10 minutes instead of fried for an oil-free alternative.

Recipe: Basic Crispy Croutons

Ingredients: bread, olive oil, salt, garlic powder

Instructions: Cut stale or leftover sandwich bread into uniform half-inch square cubes. Place the bread cubes into a large bowl, drizzle generously with olive oil, and season with salt and garlic powder, tossing thoroughly to ensure even distribution. Spread the cubes in a single layer on a baking pan and bake at 180°C for 12 to 15 minutes until completely crunchy and dry.

Substitutions: Melted butter can replace olive oil. Any dried herbs can be added.

Recipe: 2-Ingredient Banana Pancakes

Ingredients: banana, eggs

Instructions: Peel a large ripe banana and place it in a bowl. Use a fork to mash the banana completely until it turns into a smooth, liquid purée with no large lumps left. Crack two eggs directly into the mashed banana and beat vigorously with a fork until a uniform batter forms. Heat a greased non-stick skillet over medium-low heat, pour small circles of batter, and cook for 2 minutes per side until set.

Substitutions: Flips best if kept small. A spoonful of flour can be added if the batter feels too fragile to flip.

Recipe: Simple Sugar Syrup (Simple Syrup)

Ingredients: sugar, water

Instructions: Combine equal parts white granulated sugar and water in a small saucepan. Bring the mixture to a boil over medium heat, stirring constantly until all sugar crystals disappear completely and the liquid

turns perfectly clear. Remove from heat immediately and let it cool down. Store in a bottle to sweeten drinks, iced coffees, or drizzle over cakes. Substitutions: Brown sugar can be used to make a deeper, molasses-flavored rich syrup.

Recipe: Quick Mayo-Mustard Dip

Ingredients: mayonnaise, mustard, honey

Instructions: In a small serving cup or bowl, combine two tablespoons of mayonnaise and one tablespoon of mustard. Stir thoroughly with a spoon until the yellow mustard completely merges into the white mayonnaise, turning it a uniform pale yellow color. If desired, add a tiny drop of honey to balance the sharpness with sweetness. Use as a dip for fries or chicken.

Substitutions: Yellow, Dijon, or spicy mustard all work well in this base configuration.

Recipe: Basic Potato Chips

Ingredients: potatoes, oil, salt

Instructions: Wash potatoes thoroughly and slice them into paper-thin rounds using a sharp knife or mandoline. Soak the slices in cold water for 10 minutes to remove surface starch, then pat them completely dry between paper towels. Heat a deep pot of oil over high heat and fry the slices in small batches for 3 to 4 minutes until the bubbling stops and chips are golden. Salt immediately.

Substitutions: Can be made with sweet potatoes using the exact same process.

Recipe: Cheesy Tortilla Roll-ups

Ingredients: tortilla, cheese

Instructions: Lay a single flour tortilla flat on a microwave-safe plate. Sprinkle a thick, uniform layer of grated cheese across the entire surface of the tortilla, leaving a tiny clean border at the edges.

Microwave on high power for 30 to 40 seconds until the cheese is completely melted and gooey. Carefully roll the hot tortilla up into a tight log shape and slice into small pinwheels.

Substitutions: Can be toasted on a dry skillet over medium heat instead of microwaved for a crunchy crust.

Recipe: Fried Bread Pudding Cubes

Ingredients: bread, milk, sugar, oil

Instructions: Cut bread into large cubes. In a shallow bowl, whisk milk and sugar together until dissolved. Brief dip each bread cube into the sweet milk, ensuring it absorbs liquid but does not become soggy or fall apart. Heat oil in a pan and fry the soaked bread cubes for 2 minutes per side until the sugar caramelizes into a crispy brown shell while keeping the interior soft.

Substitutions: Heavy cream can replace milk for an incredibly rich dessert bite.

Recipe: Classic Potato Frittata (Spanish Tortilla)

Ingredients: potatoes, eggs, onions, oil, salt

Instructions: Slice potatoes and onions very thinly. Heat a large amount of oil in a pan and cook the potatoes and onions slowly over medium heat for 12 minutes until soft but not browned; drain off excess oil. Whisk eggs with salt in a large bowl, stir in the warm potatoes, and let sit for 5 minutes. Pour the whole mixture back into the skillet and cook on low heat for 5 minutes, flip carefully using a plate, and cook the other side.

Substitutions: Any cooking oil works, but olive oil provides the most traditional flavor profile.

Recipe: Quick Tomato Shakshuka

Ingredients: eggs, tomato sauce, onions, garlic, cumin, oil, salt

Instructions: Heat oil in a skillet and sauté chopped onions and minced garlic until soft. Add ground cumin and cook for 30 seconds, then pour in the tomato sauce and simmer for 5 minutes until thick. Use a spoon to make small wells in the sauce and crack an egg into each well. Turn the heat down to low, cover the skillet tightly with a lid, and cook for 5 to 6 minutes until egg whites are set but yolks stay runny.

Substitutions: Can add diced bell peppers along with the onions for extra volume.

Recipe: Simple French Omelet

Ingredients: eggs, butter, salt

Instructions: Whisk eggs with a pinch of salt until completely uniform and free of stringy whites. Melt butter in a non-stick skillet over medium heat. Pour in the eggs and immediately begin shaking the pan forward and backward while stirring the eggs rapidly with a fork to form tiny curds. When the egg is mostly set but still moist on top, tilt the pan and gently roll the egg sheet into a smooth, log-like cylinder.

Substitutions: Requires a good non-stick pan and a gentle heat source to prevent browning.

Recipe: Basic Italian Polenta

Ingredients: cornmeal, water, butter, salt

Instructions: Bring water and salt to a rolling boil in a saucepan. Slowly pour the cornmeal into the water in a thin, steady stream while whisking continuously to prevent lumps from forming. Turn the heat down to the lowest setting and cover. Cook for 20 to 25 minutes, stirring vigorously every 5 minutes, until the mixture pulls away from the sides and turns thick and creamy. Stir in butter before serving.

Substitutions: Milk or broth can replace water for a much more flavorful and rich porridge base.

Recipe: Easy Garlic Naan Bits

Ingredients: flour, yogurt, garlic, butter, baking powder, salt

Instructions: Combine flour, a pinch of baking powder, salt, and yogurt to form a soft dough. Roll out into small, thin teardrop shapes. Heat a heavy iron skillet until smoking hot. Slap the dough onto the dry pan; cook for 1 minute until large bubbles rise, flip, and cook the other side until charred spots appear. Melt butter with minced garlic and brush over the hot naan immediately.

Substitutions: Regular milk with a splash of vinegar can replace yogurt if needed.

Recipe: Quick Potato Gnocchi Dough

Ingredients: mashed potatoes, flour, egg, salt

Instructions: Ensure your mashed potatoes are completely cold and dry. Pile the potatoes on a counter, sprinkle flour and salt over them, and

add a beaten egg. Mix gently with your hands just until a soft, non-sticky dough forms (do not over-knead). Roll into long ropes and cut into small half-inch pillows. Drop into boiling water; they are cooked the exact moment they float to the surface.

Substitutions: Can be made without the egg, but requires a touch more flour to bind securely.

Recipe: Classic Greek Tzatziki Sauce

Ingredients: cucumber, yogurt, garlic, lemon juice, olive oil, salt

Instructions: Grate the cucumber finely and use your hands to squeeze out all excess water completely. In a bowl, combine the dry grated cucumber, thick plain yogurt, minced garlic, a splash of lemon juice, a drizzle of olive oil, and salt. Stir thoroughly and let sit in the fridge for 30 minutes before serving as a cold dip or sandwich spread.

Substitutions: Greek yogurt or hung curd works best because of its low water content.

Recipe: Simple Mexican Tomato Rice

Ingredients: rice, tomato sauce, garlic, onions, oil, water, salt

Instructions: Heat oil in a pot and add raw white rice, stirring constantly for 3 to 4 minutes until the grains turn opaque and golden brown. Add diced onions and minced garlic, cooking for 1 minute. Pour in the tomato sauce, water, and salt. Bring to a rolling boil, cover with a tight lid, reduce heat to low, and cook undisturbed for 15 minutes until fluffy.

Substitutions: Chicken stock can replace water to increase the savory background notes.

Recipe: Easy Chinese Steamed Custard

Ingredients: eggs, warm water, soy sauce, salt

Instructions: Whisk eggs and a pinch of salt together gently to avoid creating bubbles. Slowly pour in warm water (equal to double the volume of the eggs) while stirring continuously. Strain the mixture through a fine mesh sieve into a heatproof ceramic bowl to remove large bubbles. Cover the bowl with foil and steam over boiling water for 10 minutes until it sets into a delicate, jelly-like custard. Top with a drop of soy sauce.

Substitutions: Chicken broth can replace warm water for a savory explosion.

Recipe: Basic Flour Dumplings

Ingredients: flour, baking powder, milk, salt, butter

Instructions: Stir flour, baking powder, and salt together in a bowl. Melt butter and mix it with milk, then pour into the dry ingredients, stirring gently with a fork until a soft, sticky dough forms. Drop rounded spoonfuls of this dough directly into a pot of simmering soup or stew. Cover tightly with a lid and cook undisturbed for 15 minutes without opening the lid; the dumplings will steam into large, light, fluffy balls.

Substitutions: Water can replace milk if necessary.

Recipe: Classic Cinnamon Fried Bananas

Ingredients: bananas, butter, sugar, cinnamon

Instructions: Slice the bananas into even half-inch thick rounds. Melt butter in a non-stick frying pan over medium heat. Arrange the banana rounds in a single layer in the pan. Cook undisturbed for 2 minutes until the bottoms turn golden brown and soft. Flip them over carefully, sprinkle sugar and ground cinnamon heavily over the tops, and cook for another 2 minutes until the sugar melts into a hot glaze.

Substitutions: Brown sugar or honey works better than white sugar for a deeper caramelization.

Recipe: Easy Mug Brownie

Ingredients: flour, sugar, cocoa powder, water, oil, salt

Instructions: In a standard microwave-safe ceramic coffee mug, mix 4 tablespoons of flour, 4 tablespoons of sugar, and 2 tablespoons of unsweetened cocoa powder with a tiny pinch of salt. Add 3 tablespoons of water and 2 tablespoons of oil. Stir thoroughly with a small fork until a thick, smooth chocolate batter forms. Microwave on high power for 60 to 70 seconds; the center should remain slightly soft and fudgy.

Substitutions: Milk can replace water for a richer crumb structure. Add chocolate chips if available.

Recipe: Stewed Honey Pears

Ingredients: pears, water, honey, cinnamon

Instructions: Peel the fresh pears, cut them in half lengthwise, and scoop out the center cores and seeds. In a small saucepan, combine water, a generous drizzle of honey, and a dash of ground cinnamon, bringing it to a boil. Place the pear halves into the liquid, turn the heat to low, cover with a lid, and simmer gently for 15 to 20 minutes until the pears are soft enough to be cut easily with a spoon.

Substitutions: Apples can be cooked using this identical poaching method.

Recipe: Quick Chocolate Mousse

Ingredients: heavy cream, sugar, cocoa powder, vanilla extract

Instructions: Pour chilled heavy whipping cream into a large glass bowl. Add cocoa powder, sugar, and a drop of vanilla extract. Using a hand whisk or electric mixer, beat the mixture vigorously for 3 to 5 minutes until stiff peaks form and the cream transforms into a thick, fluffy, air-filled chocolate structure. Scoop into cups and chill briefly before serving.

Substitutions: Powdered sugar dissolves much faster and smoother than granular white sugar.

Recipe: Sweet Grilled Chocolate Sandwich

Ingredients: bread, chocolate chips, butter

Instructions: Butter one side of two slices of bread generously. Place one slice butter-side down in a cold skillet. Scatter chocolate chips or broken chocolate bar pieces evenly across the bread surface. Top with the second slice of bread, butter-side facing up. Cook over medium-low heat for 3 to 4 minutes until toasted, flip carefully, and toast the other side until the interior chocolate is completely melted and gooey.

Substitutions: Can add sliced bananas or peanut butter inside along with the chocolate.

Recipe: Simple Milk Peda (Instant Sweet)

Ingredients: milk powder, condensed milk, butter, cardamom powder

Instructions: In a non-stick pan over low heat, melt a tablespoon of butter. Add milk powder and sweetened condensed milk, stirring continuously to prevent burning. Cook for 4 to 5 minutes on very low heat until the mixture thickens and leaves the sides of the pan, forming a

cohesive dough ball. Stir in cardamom powder, let it cool slightly until safe to touch, and roll into smooth, flat round patties.

Substitutions: Can omit cardamom powder if unavailable; vanilla extract can stand in.

Recipe: Microwave Apple Crisp

Ingredients: apples, oats, brown sugar, butter, cinnamon

Instructions: Dice apples into small cubes and place them in a microwave-safe bowl, tossing with cinnamon and a spoonful of sugar. In a separate cup, mix oats, brown sugar, and melted butter until it forms a crumbly texture. Scatter this oat topping evenly over the diced apples. Microwave on high power for 2 to 3 minutes until the apples underneath are bubbling hot and completely tender.

Substitutions: Regular white sugar can replace brown sugar, though it loses some molasses flavor.

Recipe: Coconut Sugar Bites

Ingredients: shredded coconut, condensed milk

Instructions: In a bowl, combine shredded dry coconut and sweetened condensed milk, stirring until a thick, sticky, moldable paste forms. Use your hands to roll the mixture into small, tight, bite-sized round balls. If desired, roll the finished balls through a shallow bowl of extra dry shredded coconut to create a clean, non-sticky outer crust. Chill for 10 minutes to firm up.

Substitutions: Can use fresh grated coconut if toasted lightly in a dry pan first to remove surface moisture.

Recipe: Simple Sweet Crepes

Ingredients: flour, milk, egg, sugar, butter

Instructions: Whisk flour, sugar, milk, and an egg together until a very thin, watery batter forms without any lumps. Melt a tiny dot of butter in a large non-stick skillet over medium heat. Pour a small ladle of batter into the center and quickly swirl the pan around to spread it into an ultra-thin layer. Cook for 1 minute, flip carefully, and cook the other side for 30 seconds. Fold and serve with sugar or jam.

Substitutions: Water can replace half of the milk volume to make the crepes slightly crispier around the edges.

Recipe: Fried Sweet Dough Holes

Ingredients: self-rising flour, Greek yogurt, sugar, oil

Instructions: Mix equal parts self-rising flour and thick Greek yogurt together until a sticky dough forms. Heat oil in a deep frying pan over medium heat. Drop small, spoon-sized balls of the dough directly into the hot oil. Fry for 3 to 4 minutes, turning constantly, until they puff up into round balls and turn golden brown. Remove, drain on paper towels, and immediately roll through a bowl of sugar.

Substitutions: Regular flour mixed with a teaspoon of baking powder can replace self-rising flour.

Recipe: Easy Garlic Butter Canned Tuna

Ingredients: canned tuna, garlic, butter, lemon juice, salt

Instructions: Drain the oil or water thoroughly from the canned tuna. Melt a generous tablespoon of butter in a small skillet over medium heat. Add finely minced garlic and sauté for 1 minute until fragrant. Add the flaked tuna to the pan, breaking up large chunks with a spoon. Sauté for 3 minutes until the tuna is hot and slightly crispy at the edges. Finish with a squeeze of fresh lemon juice.

Substitutions: Olive oil can replace butter. Can be served over rice or tossed into pasta.

Recipe: Simple Pan-Seared Fish Fillet

Ingredients: white fish fillet, oil, salt, pepper, flour

Instructions: Pat the fish fillet completely dry using paper towels; this prevents sticking and ensures a crisp crust. Season both sides with salt and black pepper, then dust lightly with a thin layer of flour. Heat oil in a non-stick skillet over medium-high heat. Carefully place the fish in the pan. Cook undisturbed for 4 minutes, flip once, and cook for another 3 minutes until the fish flakes easily with a fork.

Substitutions: Cornstarch can replace flour for a gluten-free, extra-crispy exterior skin.

Recipe: Quick Salmon Foil Pack

Ingredients: salmon fillet, butter, lemon juice, garlic, salt

Instructions: Tear off a large square sheet of aluminum foil. Place the salmon fillet right in the center of the foil. Top the fish with a slice of butter, minced garlic, salt, and a heavy squeeze of lemon juice. Fold the edges of the foil up and seal them tightly to create an airtight pocket. Bake in an oven at 200°C for 12 to 14 minutes; the trapped steam cooks the fish perfectly while locking in moisture.

Substitutions: Can be cooked on a hot outdoor grill or inside a covered skillet using the exact same foil pack.

Recipe: Creamy Tuna Salad Bowls

Ingredients: canned tuna, mayonnaise, onions, salt, pepper

Instructions: Open the canned tuna and drain out all excess canning liquid. Flake the tuna into a mixing bowl using a fork. Add finely diced onions, a few spoonfuls of mayonnaise, salt, and coarsely ground black pepper. Stir all the ingredients together vigorously until smooth and well combined. Serve chilled over lettuce, with crackers, or as a cold sandwich filling.

Substitutions: Greek yogurt can replace mayonnaise. Celery or pickles can be added for crunch.

Recipe: Lemon Garlic Shrimp Skillet

Ingredients: shrimp, garlic, butter, lemon juice, salt, pepper

Instructions: Ensure shrimp are peeled and deveined. Melt butter in a large skillet over medium-high heat. Add minced garlic and cook for 30 seconds. Toss the shrimp into the pan in a flat layer. Cook for 2 minutes, flip them over, and cook for another 2 minutes until they turn fully pink, opaque, and curl slightly into a C-shape. Drizzle with lemon juice and serve.

Substitutions: Olive oil can replace butter. Frozen shrimp must be fully thawed and patted dry before cooking.

Recipe: Soy Glazed Fish Fillet

Ingredients: white fish fillet, soy sauce, sugar, ginger, oil

Instructions: Mix soy sauce, sugar, and finely grated ginger in a small cup. Heat oil in a non-stick frying pan over medium-high heat. Sear the fish fillet for 3 minutes on one side until browned, then flip over.

Immediately pour the soy-ginger mixture into the pan around the fish. Let the sauce boil rapidly and reduce for 3 minutes, spooning the sticky glaze over the top of the fish as it cooks.

Substitutions: Honey can replace sugar. Garlic can replace fresh ginger.

Recipe: Spicy Tuna Patties

Ingredients: canned tuna, egg, flour, onions, chili powder, oil, salt

Instructions: Drain canned tuna completely and place in a bowl. Mix in a beaten egg, two tablespoons of flour, finely diced onions, chili powder, and salt, stirring until a thick moldable paste forms. Shape the mixture into small, flat round patties using your hands. Heat oil in a skillet over medium-high heat and fry the patties for 3 to 4 minutes per side until they form a crunchy golden brown crust.

Substitutions: Breadcrumbs or mashed potatoes can replace flour as the binding agent.

Recipe: Quick Shrimp Fried Rice

Ingredients: shrimp, rice, soy sauce, egg, oil, garlic, green onions

Instructions: Heat oil in a wok over high heat and cook peeled shrimp for 2 minutes until pink; remove and set aside. Scramble an egg in the same pan. Throw in minced garlic and cold leftover rice, stir-frying rapidly over high heat for 3 minutes. Toss the cooked shrimp back into the pan along with soy sauce and chopped green onions, mixing everything for 1 more minute until piping hot.

Substitutions: Any diced vegetables can be fried along with the garlic to bulk up the rice.

Recipe: Tomato Braised White Fish

Ingredients: white fish fillet, tomato sauce, garlic, onions, olive oil, salt

Instructions: Heat olive oil in a deep skillet and sauté chopped onions and garlic until translucent. Pour in the tomato sauce and a pinch of salt, bringing it to a gentle simmer. Place the raw fish fillets directly into the bubbling tomato sauce. Cover the skillet tightly with a lid and cook on medium-low heat for 8 to 10 minutes; the fish will poach gently inside the sauce, staying incredibly tender.

Substitutions: Canned diced tomatoes can replace smooth tomato sauce for a rustier texture.

Recipe: Honey Garlic Salmon

Ingredients: salmon fillet, honey, soy sauce, garlic, oil

Instructions: Whisk honey, soy sauce, and minced garlic together in a bowl. Heat oil in a pan over medium-high heat. Place the salmon fillet skin-side up and sear for 4 minutes. Flip the salmon over and pour the honey-soy sauce directly into the pan. Simmer for 3 minutes on medium-low heat as the sauce bubbles, thickens, and reduces into a dark, sticky glaze that covers the salmon entirely.

Substitutions: Brown sugar can replace honey.

Recipe: Simple Flour Tortillas

Ingredients: flour, water, oil, salt

Instructions: In a large bowl, stir together two cups of flour, a teaspoon of salt, three tablespoons of oil, and a half-cup of warm water until a shaggy dough forms. Knead the dough on a counter for 5 minutes until smooth, then let it rest for 15 minutes. Divide into small balls, roll each ball out flat into thin circles using a rolling pin, and cook on a smoking-hot dry skillet for 1 minute per side until bubbly and spotted brown.

Substitutions: Butter can replace oil for a softer, flakier flatbread texture.

Recipe: Classic Tomato and Cheese Quesadilla

Ingredients: tortillas, cheese, tomatoes, butter

Instructions: Melt a dot of butter in a large frying pan. Place one flour tortilla flat in the pan. Sprinkle half of the tortilla generously with grated cheese and top with thinly sliced fresh tomatoes. Fold the empty half of the tortilla over the fillings to create a half-moon shape. Cook for 3 minutes until crisp and golden brown on the bottom, carefully flip over, and toast the other side until the cheese inside is completely melted.

Substitutions: Any flatbread or roti can replace the store-bought tortilla wrap.

Recipe: Simple Garlic Flatbread

Ingredients: flour, yogurt, garlic, butter, salt

Instructions: Mix equal parts flour and plain yogurt with a pinch of salt until a soft dough forms. Divide into balls and roll flat. Cook the flatbreads on a hot, dry pan for 2 minutes per side until they puff up and brown. In a small cup, melt butter and mix in finely minced raw garlic. Brush this hot garlic butter over the surface of the flatbreads immediately after pulling them from the pan.

Substitutions: Self-rising flour works best, but regular flour with a pinch of baking powder works too.

Recipe: Quick Mayonnaise Egg Sandwich

Ingredients: bread, egg, mayonnaise, salt, pepper, butter

Instructions: Fry an egg in a hot skillet with butter, flipping once to ensure the yolk is hard-cooked or cooked to your preference. Toast two slices of bread. Spread a thick layer of mayonnaise on the interior sides of both toast slices. Place the hot fried egg between the bread, season with salt and pepper, close the sandwich, and cut diagonally.

Substitutions: Mustard or ketchup can be mixed into the mayonnaise for extra flavor.

Recipe: Crispy Onion Grilled Cheese

Ingredients: bread, cheese, onions, butter

Instructions: Slice onions very thinly. Melt a little butter in a pan and cook the onions over medium-low heat for 10 minutes until soft, sweet, and golden brown; set aside. Assemble a standard sandwich by placing cheese and the sweet cooked onions between two slices of buttered bread. Grill the sandwich in your pan on medium-low heat for 4 minutes per side until crunchy and gooey.

Substitutions: Processed cheese slices or shredded cheddar cheese work fine.

Recipe: Basic Roti (Indian Flatbread)

Ingredients: whole wheat flour, water, salt, oil

Instructions: Mix whole wheat flour and a pinch of salt in a bowl, slowly adding water while kneading until a smooth, non-sticky dough forms.

Grease lightly with a drop of oil and let rest for 10 minutes. Roll out small portions into thin, even circles. Place on a hot iron tawa or skillet. When small bubbles appear, flip, and press gently with a clean cloth until it puffs up.

Substitutions: Regular all-purpose flour can be used but results in a chewier flatbread.

Recipe: Creamy Avocado Egg Wrap

Ingredients: tortilla, egg, avocado, salt, oil

Instructions: Scramble the egg in a hot pan with a little oil until cooked through. Mash the avocado flesh with a pinch of salt in a small bowl. Lay the tortilla flat, spread the mashed avocado down the center line, and top it with the warm scrambled eggs. Fold the sides of the tortilla tightly over the filling and roll it up into a secure wrap.

Substitutions: Flatbread, pita bread, or large lettuce leaves can replace the tortilla wrap.

Recipe: Simple Sugar Paratha

Ingredients: whole wheat flour, water, sugar, ghee

Instructions: Make a simple soft dough using whole wheat flour and water. Roll a portion into a flat circle, brush the surface with melted ghee or oil, and sprinkle a tablespoon of sugar evenly over it. Fold the dough into layers or a tight triangle, then roll it out flat again gently so the sugar stays trapped inside. Fry on a hot skillet, brushing both sides with ghee, until crispy, golden, and flakey.

Substitutions: Butter or regular cooking oil can replace ghee. Brown sugar can be used.

Recipe: Peanut Butter Jelly Sandwich

Ingredients: bread, peanut butter, jelly

Instructions: Lay two slices of fresh sandwich bread flat on a clean surface. Spread a smooth, generous layer of peanut butter across one slice of bread, ensuring it covers edge-to-edge. Spread your preferred fruit jelly or jam across the second slice of bread. Press the two slices firmly together so the fillings merge, then cut in half before serving.

Substitutions: Any nut butter or seed butter can replace peanut butter. Honey can replace jelly.

Recipe: Toasted Tomato Pepper Sandwich

Ingredients: bread, tomatoes, bell peppers, cheese, butter

Instructions: Dice tomatoes and bell peppers finely and mix them with a small handful of grated cheese. Season with salt. Place this veggie-cheese mixture between two slices of bread. Melt butter in a skillet, place the sandwich inside, and weight it down with a heavy plate or second pan. Grill for 3 minutes per side on medium heat until the bread turns brown and the interior veggies are hot and bound by cheese.

Substitutions: Mayonnaise can be used inside to help bind the diced vegetables together.

Recipe: Quick Black Bean Stew

Ingredients: canned black beans, onion, garlic, cumin, oil, salt

Instructions: Do not drain the canned black beans; the starchy canning liquid forms the stew base. Heat oil in a small pot and sauté diced onions and minced garlic until translucent. Stir in a teaspoon of ground cumin and toast for 10 seconds. Pour in the beans along with their liquid. Bring to a boil, then lower heat and simmer for 10 minutes, mashing a few beans against the side of the pot to thicken the gravy.

Substitutions: Canned pinto beans or kidney beans work beautifully with this exact same flavor profile.

Recipe: Simple Red Lentil Dahl

Ingredients: red lentils, water, onion, garlic, oil, turmeric, cumin, salt

Instructions: Rinse the red lentils thoroughly under cold water. In a pot, heat oil and cook diced onions and minced garlic until golden. Stir in turmeric powder and cumin powder, then add the rinsed lentils and water. Bring to a boil, then reduce heat to low and cover with a lid. Simmer for 20 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the lentils completely break down into a thick, creamy, porridge-like consistency. Season with salt.

Substitutions: Yellow split peas can be used but require double the cooking time.

Recipe: Easy Chickpea Curry

Ingredients: canned chickpeas, tomato sauce, onion, garlic, curry powder, oil, salt

Instructions: Heat oil in a pan and sauté chopped onions and garlic until soft. Add a tablespoon of curry powder and stir rapidly to release oils. Pour in the tomato sauce and bring to a simmer. Drain the chickpeas and add them to the bubbling tomato sauce. Simmer uncovered on medium-low heat for 12 to 15 minutes until the sauce thickens and thoroughly flavors the chickpeas.

Substitutions: Can use diced fresh tomatoes instead of canned tomato sauce.

Recipe: Basic White Bean Soup

Ingredients: canned white beans, chicken broth, garlic, olive oil, rosemary, salt

Instructions: In a pot, heat olive oil and sauté minced garlic and a pinch of dried rosemary for 1 minute. Drain and rinse the canned white beans, then add them to the pot along with the chicken broth. Bring to a boil, then simmer for 10 minutes. Use the back of a large spoon to mash some of the beans against the side of the pot to create a rich, creamy broth consistency.

Substitutions: Vegetable broth can replace chicken broth. Thyme can replace rosemary.

Recipe: Classic Potato Leek Soup

Ingredients: potatoes, leeks, butter, water, salt, pepper

Instructions: Slice the white and light green parts of the leeks thinly, washing thoroughly to remove grit. Peel and dice the potatoes. Melt butter in a large pot and sauté the leeks for 5 minutes until soft. Add the diced potatoes and cover with water and salt. Bring to a boil, then simmer for 20 minutes until potatoes are falling apart. Mash or blend into a smooth, thick, comforting soup.

Substitutions: Onions can completely replace leeks if they are unavailable in your pantry.

Recipe: Simple Garlic Broth

Ingredients: garlic, water, oil, salt, egg, bread

Instructions: Slice an entire head of garlic cloves thinly. Heat oil in a pot and fry the garlic slices slowly until golden brown. Pour in water and salt, bringing to a rolling boil, then simmer for 15 minutes to infuse the liquid with garlic essence. Place a piece of stale bread into the bottom of a serving bowl, crack a raw egg over the bread, and ladle the boiling hot garlic broth directly over it to cook the egg instantly.

Substitutions: Chicken broth can replace water for a richer base.

Recipe: Spiced Lentil Soup

Ingredients: brown lentils, onions, carrots, oil, cumin, water, salt

Instructions: Dice the onions and carrots into small pieces. Heat oil in a deep pot and sauté the vegetables for 5 minutes. Stir in ground cumin. Add washed dry brown lentils and cover with water. Bring to a boil, then reduce heat, cover with a lid, and simmer slowly for 35 to 40 minutes until the lentils are completely tender and soft. Season with salt before serving.

Substitutions: Can add a spoonful of tomato paste to boost the soup color and flavor profile.

Recipe: Clear Vegetable Broth Soup

Ingredients: carrots, onions, celery, water, salt, pepper, oil

Instructions: Chop all vegetables into small, uniform bite-sized pieces. Heat a tiny bit of oil in a pot and sauté the vegetables for 3 minutes to unlock sweetness. Pour in water, salt, and black pepper, bringing the liquid to a boil. Turn the heat to low, cover with a lid, and simmer for 20 minutes until all vegetables are completely tender and the water transforms into a flavorful clear broth.

Substitutions: Can throw in any cabbage, cabbage core, or potato peels to add depth to the broth.

Recipe: Quick Chili Bean Bowls

Ingredients: canned kidney beans, tomato sauce, onion, chili powder, oil, salt

Instructions: Heat oil in a pan and cook diced onions until soft and brown. Stir in a generous tablespoon of chili powder to toast. Add the canned kidney beans (with their liquid) and the tomato sauce. Stir thoroughly and simmer on medium heat for 12 minutes until the liquid reduces into a thick, spicy, rich chili gravy. Serve hot in bowls.

Substitutions: Can add ground meat or texturized vegetable protein if available.

Recipe: Comforting Chicken Noodle Soup

Ingredients: chicken breast, instant noodles, water, carrots, salt, pepper

Instructions: Dice the raw chicken breast and carrots into very small pieces. Bring water and salt to a boil in a pot. Add the chicken and carrots, cooking for 8 minutes until the chicken turns fully white and the carrots soften. Drop in an instant noodle cake (without the seasoning pack) and cook for another 3 minutes until noodles are tender. Season with black pepper.

Substitutions: Can use chicken bouillon or leftover roasted chicken instead of raw breast.

Recipe: Classic Sautéed Mushrooms

Ingredients: mushrooms, butter, garlic, salt, pepper

Instructions: Clean the mushrooms with a dry paper towel and slice them thick. Melt butter in a wide frying pan over medium-high heat. Add the mushrooms in a single layer. Let them cook without moving for 3 minutes to develop a brown crust. Stir, add minced garlic, salt, and black pepper, and cook for another 3 to 4 minutes until the mushrooms release their liquids and soften beautifully.

Substitutions: Olive oil can replace butter. Can add a splash of soy sauce for deep umami notes.

Recipe: Garlic Roasted Potatoes

Ingredients: potatoes, olive oil, garlic, salt, pepper

Instructions: Preheat your oven to 200°C. Wash and cut the potatoes into uniform one-inch chunks, leaving the skin on for texture. In a large bowl, toss the potato chunks with olive oil, minced garlic, salt, and black pepper until evenly coated. Spread the potatoes in a single layer on a baking sheet. Roast for 30 to 35 minutes, flipping halfway through, until crispy on the outside and fluffy inside.

Substitutions: Melted butter can replace olive oil. Garlic powder can replace fresh garlic.

Recipe: Simple Glazed Carrots

Ingredients: carrots, butter, honey, salt, water

Instructions: Peel the carrots and slice them diagonally into half-inch rounds. Place the carrots, a half-cup of water, a tablespoon of butter, and a tablespoon of honey into a saucepan with a pinch of salt. Bring to a boil over medium heat, then cover and cook for 8 minutes until carrots are fork-tender. Remove the lid and cook over high heat until the water evaporates and the butter-honey mix forms a thick glaze.

Substitutions: Sugar or brown sugar can replace honey. Parsley makes a great garnish.

Recipe: Crispy Roasted Broccoli

Ingredients: broccoli, oil, salt, pepper, garlic powder

Instructions: Cut the broccoli head into medium-sized florets. Ensure the florets are completely dry. Toss them with a generous amount of oil, salt, pepper, and garlic powder in a bowl. Spread them across a baking sheet, ensuring plenty of space between pieces. Roast at 220°C for 15 to 18 minutes until the edges and tips of the florets are charred and crispy.

Substitutions: Cauliflower can be roasted using the exact same method.

Recipe: Buttered Sweet Corn

Ingredients: corn kernels, butter, salt, pepper

Instructions: If using canned corn, drain the liquid thoroughly. If using frozen, thaw briefly. Melt butter in a small saucepan or skillet over medium heat. Add the corn kernels and toss to coat in the melted butter. Cook for 4 to 5 minutes, stirring frequently, until the corn is heated through and turns a bright, vibrant yellow. Season with salt and black pepper to taste.

Substitutions: Add a pinch of chili powder and lime juice to turn it into an easy street-style corn side.

Recipe: Steamed Garlic Green Beans

Ingredients: green beans, garlic, oil, water, salt

Instructions: Trim the woody stem ends off the green beans. Heat a tablespoon of oil in a skillet over medium heat and sauté minced garlic for 30 seconds. Toss in the green beans and sauté for 1 minute. Pour in two tablespoons of water and immediately cover the skillet with a lid to

trap the steam. Cook for 3 to 4 minutes until the beans turn bright green and tender-crisp, then season with salt.

Substitutions: Butter can be used instead of oil for sautéing.

Recipe: Classic Mashed Potatoes

Ingredients: potatoes, butter, milk, salt, pepper

Instructions: Peel potatoes and cut into large chunks. Place in a pot of cold salted water, bring to a boil, and cook for 15 minutes until easily pierced with a fork. Drain completely and return potatoes to the warm pot. Add butter and mash thoroughly using a potato masher or sturdy fork. Slowly pour in warm milk while mashing until your desired creamy texture is reached. Season generously with salt.

Substitutions: Heavy cream or sour cream can replace milk for richer texture.

Recipe: Simple Cucumber Salad

Ingredients: cucumber, vinegar, sugar, salt, onions

Instructions: Slice the cucumbers and onions very thinly and place them in a mixing bowl. In a separate small bowl, whisk together white vinegar, a spoonful of sugar, and a pinch of salt until the sugar dissolves completely. Pour this tangy dressing over the cucumbers and onions, toss well to ensure every slice is coated, and let it marinate in the fridge for 15 minutes before serving.

Substitutions: Lemon juice can replace vinegar. Red onions look best but white onions work fine.

Recipe: Sautéed Cabbage and Onions

Ingredients: cabbage, onions, butter, salt, pepper

Instructions: Shred the cabbage finely and slice the onions thinly. Melt a generous block of butter in a large deep skillet over medium heat. Add the onions and cabbage, stirring well to coat with butter. Cook uncovered for 15 to 20 minutes, stirring occasionally, as the cabbage wilts down dramatically and caramelizes with the onions into a sweet, tender side dish. Season with salt and pepper.

Substitutions: Cooking oil or bacon fat can replace butter.

Recipe: Honey Roasted Sweet Potatoes

Ingredients: sweet potatoes, oil, honey, cinnamon, salt

Instructions: Scrub the sweet potatoes clean and dice them into cubes. Toss the cubes with oil, a drizzle of honey, a pinch of salt, and a dash of ground cinnamon. Spread them onto a greased baking sheet and roast at 200°C for 25 minutes, stirring once halfway through, until the sweet potatoes are tender and the honey edges turn sticky and caramelized.

Substitutions: Maple syrup or brown sugar can replace honey.

Recipe: Creamy Garlic Spinach

Ingredients: spinach, garlic, heavy cream, butter, salt

Instructions: Melt butter in a wide pan and sauté minced garlic for 30 seconds. Add fresh spinach leaves in batches, letting them wilt down before adding more. Once all spinach is wilted, turn the heat to low and pour in a few tablespoons of heavy cream. Stir continuously for 2 minutes until the cream reduces slightly and coats the spinach leaves in a rich sauce. Season with salt.

Substitutions: Milk mixed with a tiny bit of cornstarch can replace heavy cream.

Recipe: Pan-Fried Zucchini Rounds

Ingredients: zucchini, oil, salt, pepper, garlic powder

Instructions: Slice the zucchini into uniform quarter-inch thick rounds. Heat oil in a wide frying pan over medium-high heat. Arrange the zucchini

slices in a single layer in the pan. Cook for 3 minutes until the bottom side develops a deep brown color, flip them over, and cook the other side for another 2 to 3 minutes until tender but not mushy. Season with salt, pepper, and garlic powder.

Substitutions: Can coat the zucchini slices in flour or cornstarch before frying for a crispier skin texture.

Recipe: Simple Tomato Soup

Ingredients: canned tomatoes, onion, garlic, butter, water, salt

Instructions: Melt butter in a pot and cook diced onions and minced garlic until soft. Pour in a can of crushed tomatoes along with a half-cup of water and a pinch of salt. Bring to a boil, then turn the heat down and simmer gently for 15 minutes. Use a blender to puree the soup until smooth, or leave it chunky depending on preference. Serve hot.

Substitutions: Fresh ripe tomatoes can be used if boiled down for a longer period of time.

Recipe: Sesame Ginger Glazed Bok Choy

Ingredients: bok choy, garlic, ginger, soy sauce, sesame oil

Instructions: Slice the bok choy heads in half lengthwise and wash out any dirt. Heat sesame oil in a skillet over high heat. Place the bok choy cut-side down in the hot pan and sear for 2 minutes until lightly charred. Flip over, add minced garlic, grated ginger, a splash of water, and soy sauce. Cover with a lid immediately and steam for 3 minutes until stalks are tender.

Substitutions: Regular vegetable oil can replace sesame oil. Regular cabbage wedges can be used.

Recipe: Oven-Baked Carrot Fries

Ingredients: carrots, oil, salt, paprika, cornstarch

Instructions: Peel the carrots and slice them into long, thin matchsticks resembling french fries. Toss the carrot sticks with a teaspoon of cornstarch first (this absorbs moisture for crispiness), then coat with oil, salt, and paprika. Arrange in a clean single layer on a baking sheet and bake at 200°C for 20 to 22 minutes until edges are wrinkled and crispy.

Substitutions: Chili powder can replace paprika for spicy fries.

Recipe: Classic Hard-Boiled Eggs

Ingredients: eggs, water

Instructions: Place your eggs in a single layer at the bottom of a saucepan and cover them with cold water by at least one inch. Bring the water to a full rolling boil over high heat. As soon as it boils, turn off the heat completely, cover the pan with a tight lid, and let it sit undisturbed for exactly 11 minutes. Remove eggs and plunge them into ice water before peeling.

Substitutions: Let them sit for 6 minutes for soft-boiled eggs with a runny yolk center.

Recipe: Simple Pan-Seared Chicken Breast

Ingredients: chicken breast, oil, salt, pepper, garlic powder

Instructions: Season both sides of the chicken breast heavily with salt, black pepper, and garlic powder. Heat oil in a heavy skillet or cast-iron pan over medium-high heat. Once hot, place the chicken in the pan. Cook undisturbed for 5 to 6 minutes until the bottom develops a deep golden crust. Flip the chicken over, turn the heat down to medium, and cook for another 5 to 6 minutes until cooked through. Rest for 3 minutes before slicing.

Substitutions: Chicken thighs can be used and are more forgiving against overcooking.

Recipe: Garlic Butter Chicken Bites

Ingredients: chicken breast, garlic, butter, oil, salt, pepper

Instructions: Dice the chicken breast into small, bite-sized one-inch cubes. Season with salt and pepper. Heat a splash of oil and a tablespoon of butter in a skillet over high heat. Add the chicken cubes in a single layer and sear for 3 minutes until browned. Toss the chicken, drop in lots of minced fresh garlic and another pat of butter, reducing heat to medium. Sauté for 3 more minutes until garlic is fragrant and chicken is cooked.

Substitutions: Turkey breast or firm tofu blocks can replace chicken breast.

Recipe: Classic Egg Salad

Ingredients: eggs, mayonnaise, mustard, salt, pepper

Instructions: Hard-boil your eggs, peel them, and cool them completely. Place the eggs in a medium bowl and use a fork or potato masher to crush them into small pieces. Add mayonnaise, a small dollop of mustard, salt, and black pepper. Stir all the ingredients together thoroughly until smooth, creamy, and evenly distributed. Serve chilled as a sandwich filling.

Substitutions: Greek yogurt can replace mayonnaise for a lighter alternative.

Recipe: Soy Sauce Braised Eggs

Ingredients: eggs, soy sauce, water, sugar, garlic

Instructions: Soft-boil eggs for 6 minutes, then peel them carefully and set aside. In a small deep saucepan, combine equal parts soy sauce and water, a spoonful of sugar, and a smashed garlic clove. Bring this liquid to a brief boil until the sugar dissolves, then let it cool down.

Submerge the peeled eggs completely in the soy liquid and marinate in the fridge for at least 4 hours before slicing.

Substitutions: Add a slice of ginger or star anise to the marinade for extra flavor elements.

Recipe: Crispy Chicken Tenders

Ingredients: chicken breast, flour, egg, breadcrumbs, oil, salt

Instructions: Cut chicken breast into long, thin strips. Set up three shallow bowls: one with flour (seasoned with salt), one with a beaten egg, and one with breadcrumbs. Dredge each chicken strip in the flour, dip into the egg wash, and coat thoroughly with breadcrumbs. Heat oil in a deep skillet over medium-high heat and fry the strips for 3 to 4 minutes per side until crunchy and golden.

Substitutions: Crushed cornflakes or potato chips can replace breadcrumbs for an ultra-crispy coating.

Recipe: Egg in a Hole

Ingredients: bread, egg, butter, salt, pepper

Instructions: Use a cookie cutter or the rim of a clean glass to punch out a circular two-inch hole from the center of a slice of bread. Melt butter in a skillet over medium heat. Place the bread slice in the pan. Crack the egg directly into the center hole. Cook for 3 minutes until the bottom of the bread is toasted and the egg white sets. Carefully flip the whole slice over and cook for another 2 minutes.

Substitutions: Can use a knife to cut a square hole instead of a round one.

Recipe: One-Pan Chicken and Onions

Ingredients: chicken thighs, onions, oil, salt, pepper, rosemary

Instructions: Season chicken thighs with salt, pepper, and dried rosemary. Slice onions into thick wedges. Heat oil in a large skillet over medium-high heat. Place the chicken thighs skin-side down in the pan, scattering the onion wedges all around them. Cook for 8 minutes until the chicken skin is deeply browned. Flip the chicken, stir the onions, cover the pan with a lid, and cook on medium-low for 15 minutes until chicken is tender.

Substitutions: Thyme or oregano can replace rosemary. Chicken breasts can be used but cook faster.

Recipe: Simple Egg Drop Soup

Ingredients: eggs, chicken broth, soy sauce, cornstarch, water, green onions

Instructions: Bring chicken broth and a splash of soy sauce to a gentle simmer in a pot. In a small cup, mix a teaspoon of cornstarch with a tablespoon of cold water and stir it into the broth to thicken it slightly. Whisk the eggs thoroughly in a bowl. Turn the heat to low, stir the broth in a circular motion to create a slow whirlpool, and slowly drizzle the beaten eggs into the moving liquid to form thin egg ribbons. Top with green onions.

Substitutions: Vegetable stock can replace chicken broth. Cornstarch can be omitted, though soup will be thinner.

Recipe: Honey Mustard Chicken

Ingredients: chicken breast, honey, mustard, oil, salt, pepper

Instructions: In a small bowl, mix equal parts honey and mustard with a pinch of salt and pepper to create a glaze. Season chicken breasts with salt and pepper, then sear them in a hot skillet with oil for 4 minutes on one side. Flip the chicken over, pour the honey-mustard glaze evenly over the tops of the breasts, reduce heat to medium-low, cover, and cook for 6 minutes until the chicken is glazed and cooked through.

Substitutions: Dijon mustard, yellow mustard, or whole-grain mustard can be used.

Recipe: Microwave Scrambled Eggs

Ingredients: eggs, milk, butter, salt, pepper

Instructions: Coat the inside of a microwave-safe mug with a small smear of butter. Crack two eggs into the mug, add a tablespoon of milk, a pinch

of salt, and pepper, beating thoroughly with a fork. Microwave on high power for 45 seconds, remove and stir the contents up. Microwave for another 30 to 45 seconds until the eggs are puffed up and set. Stir one last time and serve.

Substitutions: Water can replace milk. Can stir in grated cheese before the second microwave blast.

Recipe: Chicken Stir-Fry Strips

Ingredients: chicken breast, soy sauce, garlic, ginger, oil, bell peppers, onions

Instructions: Slice chicken breast into thin strips. Heat oil in a large skillet or wok over very high heat. Add the chicken strips, minced garlic, and grated ginger, stir-frying rapidly for 4 minutes until the chicken turns white. Toss in sliced bell peppers and onions, cooking for another 3 minutes. Pour in soy sauce, tossing continuously for 1 minute until everything is hot and glazed.

Substitutions: Any crisp vegetable like broccoli, cabbage, or carrots can be thrown in.

Recipe: Puffy Baked Omelet (Frittata)

Ingredients: eggs, milk, cheese, onions, oil, salt

Instructions: Whisk eggs, milk, salt, and pepper together in a bowl. In an oven-safe skillet, heat oil and sauté diced onions until soft. Pour the egg mixture directly into the skillet over the onions and sprinkle cheese over the top. Let the edges set on the stove for 2 minutes, then transfer the entire skillet into an oven preheated to 180°C. Bake for 10 to 12 minutes until the center is puffed and firm.

Substitutions: Can be baked in a greased cake pan or pie dish if you don't have an oven-safe skillet.

Recipe: Savory Poached Eggs

Ingredients: eggs, water, vinegar, salt

Instructions: Fill a wide skillet with two inches of water, add a teaspoon of vinegar and a pinch of salt, bringing it to a bare simmer (tiny bubbles, not a rolling boil). Crack an egg into a small cup. Gently tip the egg into the simmering water. Cook undisturbed for 3 to 4 minutes until the egg white is completely opaque but the yolk remains soft and fluid. Remove carefully with a slotted spoon.

Substitutions: Vinegar helps the egg white coagulate smoothly but can be omitted if your eggs are very fresh.

Recipe: Sweet and Savory Chicken Glaze

Ingredients: chicken thighs, brown sugar, soy sauce, garlic, oil

Instructions: Mix brown sugar, soy sauce, and minced garlic together until sugar dissolves. Heat oil in a frying pan and cook chicken thighs for 5 minutes per side until heavily browned. Pour the sweet soy mixture directly into the pan with the chicken. Bring to a boil, then turn the heat down to low, letting the sauce simmer and reduce into a sticky, thick glaze coating the chicken entirely.

Substitutions: Honey or maple syrup can replace brown sugar.

Recipe: Creamy Butter Parmesan Pasta

Ingredients: pasta, butter, parmesan cheese, pasta water, pepper

Instructions: Boil the pasta in salted water. Just before draining, scoop out half a cup of the starchy pasta water and set it aside. Drain the pasta. In the warm empty pot, melt a generous block of butter over low heat. Add the hot pasta back into the pot, toss with grated parmesan cheese and black pepper. Pour in a few splashes of the reserved hot pasta water, stirring vigorously until a smooth, velvety cheese sauce coats the noodles.

Substitutions: Any hard cheese like processed cheddar can stand in for parmesan. Garlic butter adds a great upgrade.

Recipe: Simple Garlic Oil Pasta (Aglio e Olio)

Ingredients: pasta, garlic, olive oil, red pepper flakes, parsley

Instructions: Cook the pasta in a large pot of boiling salted water until al dente. While it cooks, slice several cloves of garlic very thinly. Heat a generous amount of olive oil in a large skillet over low heat. Add the sliced garlic and red pepper flakes, cooking slowly for 3 to 4 minutes until the garlic is golden brown but not burnt. Drain pasta, toss it into the oil, add chopped parsley, and stir well.

Substitutions: Regular cooking oil can be used, though olive oil tastes best. Dried chili flakes or fresh green chilies work fine.

Recipe: Classic Tomato Risotto

Ingredients: rice, tomato sauce, onion, garlic, butter, water, salt

Instructions: Heat a cup of water or vegetable broth in a small pan and keep it warm. In a separate saucepan, melt butter and sauté chopped onions and minced garlic until translucent. Add the rice and stir for 1 minute to toast the grains. Pour in the tomato sauce and a splash of the warm water, stirring continuously on medium heat. As the rice absorbs liquid, keep adding water a half-cup at a time, stirring constantly for 20 minutes until rice is creamy and tender.

Substitutions: Arborio rice is standard, but regular short-grain white rice works in a pinch.

Recipe: Lemon Herb Rice

Ingredients: rice, lemon juice, butter, garlic, parsley, salt

Instructions: Cook your white rice using your standard boiling method until fluffy. While the rice is hot in the pot, add a tablespoon of butter, the juice of half a fresh lemon, finely minced garlic, and chopped parsley. Stir gently with a fork to fluff the rice grains and distribute the flavor elements without mashing the rice. Let it sit covered for 2 minutes before serving.

Substitutions: Lime juice can replace lemon juice. Cilantro or coriander leaves can replace parsley.

Recipe: One-Pot Tomato Pasta

Ingredients: pasta, tomato sauce, water, onions, garlic, olive oil, salt

Instructions: In a large deep skillet or pot, place your uncooked dry pasta noodles, a can of tomato sauce, thinly sliced onions, chopped garlic, a tablespoon of olive oil, and salt. Pour in just enough water to barely submerge the pasta lines. Bring the mixture to a rolling boil over high heat. Cook uncovered for 9 to 11 minutes, stirring frequently to keep noodles from sticking, until the liquid reduces into a thick, rich sauce and the pasta is soft.

Substitutions: Can add diced tomatoes or ketchup to boost the sauce base. Any pasta shape works.

Recipe: Soy Sauce Sesame Noodles

Ingredients: pasta, soy sauce, sesame oil, sugar, garlic

Instructions: Boil your pasta or noodles in water until soft, then drain thoroughly. In a small mixing bowl, whisk together the soy sauce, sesame oil, a spoonful of sugar, and very finely minced raw garlic until the sugar dissolves completely. Pour this savory sauce directly over the warm, drained noodles. Toss well using tongs or forks until the noodles are completely coated.

Substitutions: Spaghetti or instant noodle cakes can replace Asian noodles. Regular vegetable oil can replace sesame oil if needed.

Recipe: Cheesy Rice Casserole

Ingredients: rice, cheese, milk, butter, flour, salt

Instructions: Cook your rice and set it aside. In a saucepan, melt butter and whisk in flour to make a paste. Slowly pour in milk while whisking to avoid lumps, cooking until it thickens into a white sauce. Stir in grated cheese until completely melted. Pour this cheese sauce over your cooked rice in a baking dish, stir to mix, and scatter more cheese on top. Bake or microwave until the top layer is bubbling and browned.

Substitutions: Leftover rice works perfectly. Any block cheese can be grated and used.

Recipe: Curried Fried Rice

Ingredients: rice, curry powder, onions, oil, peas, egg

Instructions: Heat oil in a pan and sauté diced onions until soft. Add a teaspoon of curry powder and toast it in the oil for 30 seconds. Crack in an egg and scramble it into bits. Add cold leftover rice and green peas into the pan. Crank the heat up high and stir-fry everything together rapidly for 3 minutes, breaking up rice clumps, until the rice is fully stained yellow and hot.

Substitutions: Any frozen mixed vegetables can replace peas. Tofu or chopped chicken can replace the egg.

Recipe: Simple Mushroom Pasta

Ingredients: pasta, mushrooms, garlic, oil, salt, pepper

Instructions: Cook the pasta according to package instructions. Clean and slice the mushrooms thinly. Heat oil in a pan over high heat, throw in the mushrooms, and cook undisturbed for 3 minutes to brown them. Add minced garlic, salt, and pepper, stirring for another 2 minutes until the mushrooms are tender and juicy. Toss the drained pasta into the mushroom pan with a splash of pasta water and serve.

Substitutions: Button, cremini, or canned mushrooms all work well. Butter can replace cooking oil.

Recipe: Ginger Garlic Rice Broth (Congee)

Ingredients: rice, water, ginger, garlic, soy sauce, green onions

Instructions: Place one cup of white rice and six cups of water into a deep pot. Add thick slices of smashed fresh ginger and crushed garlic cloves. Bring to a rolling boil, then reduce the heat to low and cover with a lid, leaving a tiny crack. Simmer slowly for 45 to 60 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the grains break down completely into a thick, smooth, comforting porridge. Serve seasoned with a drizzle of soy sauce and chopped green onions.

Substitutions: Can use chicken broth instead of water for more flavor depth.

Recipe: Creamy Tomato Shells

Ingredients: pasta, tomato sauce, heavy cream, garlic, butter, salt

Instructions: Cook shell pasta in boiling salted water. In a pan, melt butter and cook minced garlic for 1 minute. Add the tomato sauce and bring to a simmer. Turn the heat down to low and stir in the heavy cream slowly to turn the sauce a rich pink color. Season with salt. Drain the

pasta and pour it into the pink sauce, stirring until the hollow shells are completely filled with sauce.

Substitutions: Whole milk can replace heavy cream if simmered very gently to avoid curdling.

Recipe: Basic Cumin Rice (Jeera Rice)

Ingredients: rice, cumin seeds, oil, water, salt

Instructions: Wash the raw rice thoroughly. Heat oil or ghee in a pot over medium heat. Add a generous tablespoon of whole cumin seeds and let them sizzle for 20 seconds until aromatic and slightly darker. Pour in the raw rice and stir for 1 minute to coat the grains in the spiced oil. Add water and salt, bring to a boil, then cover and cook on low heat for 15 minutes until water is absorbed.

Substitutions: Any white rice variant can be used. Butter can replace oil.

Recipe: Black Pepper Beef-Flavored Noodles

Ingredients: instant noodles, soy sauce, black pepper, butter, garlic

Instructions: Cook an instant noodle cake in boiling water without its seasoning packet, then drain. In a skillet, melt a tablespoon of butter and cook minced garlic until aromatic. Add a tablespoon of soy sauce and a large pinch of coarsely ground black pepper. Throw the noodles into the pan and toss rapidly over high heat for 1 minute until the sauce coats the strands heavily.

Substitutions: Can add a bouillon cube or stock powder to intensify the savory flavor profile.

Recipe: Simple Spinach Pasta

Ingredients: pasta, spinach, garlic, olive oil, salt, parmesan cheese

Instructions: Boil the pasta. In a large skillet, heat olive oil and cook minced garlic for 30 seconds. Throw in fresh spinach leaves and cook for 2 minutes until completely wilted and reduced in volume. Drain the pasta and transfer it into the skillet with the spinach. Toss well, season with salt, and top with a dusting of grated parmesan cheese.

Substitutions: Frozen spinach can be used if thawed and squeezed entirely dry first.

Recipe: Easy Tomato Rice (Thakkali Sadam)

Ingredients: rice, tomatoes, onions, garlic, oil, mustard seeds, turmeric powder, salt

Instructions: Heat oil in a pan and add mustard seeds until they pop. Sauté sliced onions and minced garlic until soft. Add chopped tomatoes, turmeric powder, and salt, cooking down until the tomatoes turn into a soft, mushy paste and oil separates. Gently fold in pre-cooked or leftover cold rice until the grains are uniformly mixed with the spiced tomato base.

Substitutions: Chili powder can be added for heat. Any neutral oil works.

Recipe: Classic Scrambled Eggs

Ingredients: eggs, butter, milk, salt, pepper

Instructions: Crack the eggs into a bowl, add a splash of milk, and whisk vigorously until smooth and combined. Melt butter in a non-stick skillet over medium-low heat. Pour in the egg mixture and let it sit for a few seconds. Using a spatula, gently lift and fold the eggs from the edges to the center. Cook slowly, stirring gently, until moist curds form and the eggs are no longer liquid. Season with salt and pepper right before pulling off the heat.

Substitutions: Water or heavy cream can replace milk. Olive oil or cooking spray can be used instead of butter.

Recipe: Cinnamon Sugar Toast

Ingredients: bread, butter, sugar, cinnamon

Instructions: Toast the slices of bread in a toaster or on a dry skillet until crispy and golden brown. While hot, immediately spread a generous, even layer of butter on one side of each slice so it melts deep into the bread. In a small cup, mix the granulated sugar and ground cinnamon together. Sprinkle the cinnamon-sugar blend evenly over the melted butter. Serve immediately while warm.

Substitutions: Brown sugar or honey can replace white sugar. Coconut oil can be used instead of butter.

Recipe: Basic Oatmeal Porridge

Ingredients: oats, water, milk, sugar, salt

Instructions: Bring water and a tiny pinch of salt to a boil in a small saucepan over medium heat. Stir in the oats and reduce the heat to low. Simmer gently for about 5 minutes, stirring occasionally to keep it from sticking to the bottom. Once the oats have absorbed most of the liquid and turned creamy, stir in the milk and sugar. Cook for 1 more minute until heated through, then remove from heat.

Substitutions: Can be made entirely with water or entirely with milk. Honey, jagger, or maple syrup can replace sugar.

Recipe: Fluffy Pancakes

Ingredients: flour, milk, egg, butter, sugar, baking powder, salt

Instructions: Whisk the flour, sugar, baking powder, and a pinch of salt together in a large bowl. In a separate bowl, beat the egg and whisk in the milk and melted butter. Pour the wet ingredients into the dry ingredients and stir gently just until combined; leaves small lumps in the batter. Heat a lightly greased skillet over medium heat. Pour small scoops of batter onto the skillet. Cook until bubbles form on the surface, flip, and cook the other side until golden.

Substitutions: Self-rising flour can replace all-purpose flour and baking powder. Plant milk can replace dairy milk.

Recipe: Simple Banana Smoothie

Ingredients: banana, milk, honey, yogurt

Instructions: Peel the ripe banana and chop it into a few large chunks. Place the banana pieces, milk, yogurt, and honey into a blender. Secure the lid tightly and blend on high speed for 30 to 60 seconds until completely smooth, creamy, and free of lumps. Pour into a tall glass and consume immediately.

Substitutions: Use frozen banana chunks for a thicker, colder smoothie texture. Water or juice can replace milk if yogurt is kept.

Recipe: Garlic Butter Crostini

Ingredients: baguette, garlic, butter, olive oil, salt

Instructions: Slice the baguette into thin, diagonal rounds. Melt the butter together with a splash of olive oil in a pan. Press or mince the

garlic finely and mix it into the warm butter. Brush both sides of each bread slice generously with the garlic-butter mixture and place them on a baking sheet. Broil or toast in a hot skillet for 2 to 3 minutes per side until crunchy and browned around the edges.

Substitutions: Any stale regular bread or sandwich bread can be cut into squares to make garlic toast instead.

Recipe: Peanut Butter Banana Toast

Ingredients: bread, peanut butter, banana

Instructions: Toast your bread slice until it is firm and highly crispy. Spread a thick, smooth layer of peanut butter across the entire top surface of the toasted bread. Peel the banana and slice it into even rounds. Arrange the banana slices in overlapping rows across the top of the peanut butter layer.

Substitutions: Almond butter, hazelnut spread, or apple butter can replace peanut butter. Apple slices can replace bananas.

Recipe: Crispy French Toast

Ingredients: bread, egg, milk, cinnamon, butter, sugar

Instructions: Whisk the egg, milk, a pinch of sugar, and a dash of ground cinnamon together in a shallow dish or wide bowl. Melt butter in a frying pan over medium-low heat. Dip a slice of bread into the egg mixture, turning it over to ensure both sides are fully coated and have soaked up liquid. Place the soaked bread into the hot pan. Cook for 2 to 3 minutes per side until deep golden brown and slightly puffy.

Substitutions: Stale or dry bread absorbs the egg wash much better than fresh bread. Vanilla extract adds good flavor if available.

Recipe: Smashed Avocado Toast

Ingredients: bread, avocado, lemon juice, salt, pepper

Instructions: Slice open the avocado, remove the pit, and scoop the green flesh into a small bowl. Add a tiny squeeze of fresh lemon juice and a pinch of salt and pepper. Mash everything together using a fork until it reaches your desired consistency, keeping it slightly chunky. Toast a slice of bread until sturdy, then spread the mashed avocado evenly over the top.

Substitutions: Lime juice or vinegar can replace lemon juice to add acidity. Pinch of chili flakes adds a great kick.

Recipe: Easy Yogurt Parfait

Ingredients: yogurt, honey, oats, banana

Instructions: Scoop half of your yogurt into the bottom of a clean glass or serving bowl. Drizzle a small amount of honey directly over the yogurt layer, then add a handful of oats and half of a chopped banana. Repeat the layers by adding the rest of the yogurt, another drizzle of honey, and topping it off with the remaining oats and banana chunks.

Substitutions: Granola or crushed biscuits can replace plain oats. Any fresh fruit, berries, or jam can replace the banana.

Recipe: Quick Cheese Omelet

Ingredients: eggs, cheese, butter, salt, pepper

Instructions: Whisk the eggs with a pinch of salt and pepper until smooth. Melt butter in a small non-stick pan over medium heat. Pour in the eggs, swirling the pan to coat the bottom. Cook for 2 minutes until the edges set but the center remains slightly wet. Sprinkle grated cheese generously over one half of the omelet. Carefully fold the empty half over the cheese, cook for 30 more seconds until the cheese melts, and slide onto a plate.

Substitutions: Use any cheese variant like cheddar, processed cubes, or mozzarella. Onions and green chilies can be whisked into the eggs.

Recipe: Honey Butter Biscuits

Ingredients: biscuits, butter, honey

Instructions: Bake or warm up your store-bought or pre-made biscuits until they are piping hot. In a small microwave-safe bowl or small pan, combine equal parts butter and honey. Heat gently until the butter is completely melted, then stir the mixture thoroughly to combine. Split the hot biscuits in half and brush the interior and exterior surfaces heavily with the sweet honey butter before eating.

Substitutions: Can use regular bread rolls or sliced toast if biscuits are not available.

Recipe: Tomato Basil Bruschetta

Ingredients: bread, tomatoes, garlic, olive oil, salt, basil

Instructions: Dice the fresh tomatoes finely and place them in a bowl, draining off excess juice. Toss the tomatoes with minced garlic, a tablespoon of olive oil, chopped basil leaves, and salt. Let the mixture sit for 10 minutes to marry flavors. Toast thick slices of bread, brush them lightly with olive oil, and spoon the seasoned tomato mixture generously over the top just before serving.

Substitutions: Dried basil can replace fresh basil. Crackers or toasted pita bread can replace the regular bread slices.

Recipe: Sweet Honey Baked Apples

Ingredients: apples, butter, sugar, cinnamon, honey

Instructions: Wash the apples thoroughly, cut them in half lengthwise, and scoop out the center cores and seeds. Place the apple halves cut-side up in a baking dish. Place a small dot of butter inside each cored cavity. Sprinkle sugar and ground cinnamon heavily over the tops, then drizzle honey over everything. Pour two tablespoons of water into the bottom of the dish. Bake at 180°C for 25 minutes until the apples are completely soft and caramelized.

Substitutions: Pears can replace apples. Brown sugar works beautifully instead of white sugar.

Recipe: Cheesy Mug Pizza

Ingredients: flour, milk, oil, baking powder, tomato sauce, cheese, pepperoni

Instructions: In a microwave-safe ceramic mug, stir together 4 tablespoons of flour, a pinch of baking powder, a pinch of salt, 3 tablespoons of milk, and 1 tablespoon of oil until a thick batter forms at the bottom. Spread a tablespoon of tomato sauce evenly over the top of the batter. Sprinkle a thick layer of grated cheese and add a few slices of pepperoni. Microwave on high for 1 minute and 15 seconds until the dough rises and cheese bubbles.

Substitutions: Tomato ketchup can replace pizza sauce. Any diced vegetables can replace the pepperoni toppings.

Recipe: Crispy Home Fries

Ingredients: potatoes, onions, butter, oil, salt, garlic powder

Instructions: Dice raw potatoes into tiny half-inch cubes so they cook fast. Heat a mix of oil and butter in a large skillet over medium-high heat. Add the potatoes and diced onions, spreading them flat. Let them cook undisturbed for 4 minutes to brown the bottoms. Toss, turn, and keep cooking for another 8 to 10 minutes, reducing heat slightly, until the insides are soft and the outsides are super crispy. Season with salt and garlic powder.

Substitutions: Sweet potatoes can be used instead. Onion powder can replace fresh onions.

Recipe: Classic Garlic Tomato Pasta

Ingredients: pasta, tomatoes, garlic, olive oil, salt, pepper, basil

Instructions: Boil water in a large pot, add salt, and cook the pasta until al dente. While the pasta cooks, finely mince the garlic and chop the fresh tomatoes. Heat olive oil in a pan over medium heat, add the minced garlic, and sauté for 1 minute until fragrant. Add the chopped tomatoes, salt, and pepper to the pan, cooking down for about 5 to 7 minutes until a light sauce forms. Drain the pasta and toss it directly into the tomato sauce. Garnish with fresh basil before serving.

Substitutions: Use canned tomatoes if fresh ones are unavailable. Use dried oregano or parsley if fresh basil is missing.

Recipe: Comforting Grilled Cheese Sandwich

Ingredients: bread, cheese, butter

Instructions: Heat a non-stick skillet or pan over medium-low heat. Spread butter evenly on one side of two slices of bread. Place one slice, butter-side down, into the heated skillet. Top the bread with your preferred slices of cheese (such as Cheddar or Mozzarella). Place the second slice of bread on top, butter-side facing up. Cook for 3 to 4 minutes until the bottom slice turns golden brown. Flip the sandwich carefully and cook the other side for another 3 minutes until the cheese is completely melted and the bread is toasted.

Substitutions: Use mayonnaise instead of butter on the outside of the bread for a crispier crust. Use any meltable cheese variety available on hand.

Recipe: Quick Egg Fried Rice

Ingredients: rice, egg, soy sauce, garlic, oil, onions, carrots

Instructions: Heat a tablespoon of oil in a large wok or frying pan over high heat. Add finely chopped garlic, onions, and diced carrots, sautéing for 2 to 3 minutes until softened. Push the vegetables to one side of the pan, crack the eggs into the empty space, and scramble them quickly with your spatula until cooked through. Add pre-cooked, cooled leftover rice into the pan, breaking up any clumps. Drizzle soy sauce evenly over the rice, mix everything thoroughly, and stir-fry for an additional 2 to 3 minutes until the rice is heated through.

Substitutions: Leftover cold rice works best to prevent sogginess. Any vegetables like peas, bell peppers, or corn can be added or substituted.

Recipe: Simple Potato and Onion Hash

Ingredients: potatoes, onions, oil, salt, pepper, paprika

Instructions: Wash, peel, and finely dice the potatoes into small, even cubes. Slice the onions thinly. Heat oil in a heavy frying pan or skillet over medium-high heat. Add the diced potatoes in a single layer and cook undisturbed for 5 minutes to develop a crisp, golden crust. Stir the potatoes, add the sliced onions, and season generously with salt, black pepper, and paprika. Turn the heat down to medium, cover the pan, and cook for another 10 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the potatoes are completely tender inside and crispy outside.

Substitutions: Sweet potatoes can replace regular potatoes. Butter can be used instead of oil for a richer flavor profile.